

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · September 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Salt Lake City	75.4
#2	A+	Raleigh	75.1
#3	A+	Cincinnati	75.0
#4	A+	Hartford	70.4
#5	A+	Kansas City	69.3
#6	A	St. Louis	66.0
#7	A	Charlotte	63.8

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	C-	Chicago	27.2
#49	C-	Detroit	27.4
#48	C-	Sacramento	27.7
#47	C-	Louisville	27.8
#46	C-	Jacksonville	28.5
#45	C-	Richmond	30.9
#44	C-	Grand Rapids	31.6

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	14 cities
B+ / B / B-	16 cities
C+ / C / C-	20 cities
D	0 cities

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · September 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
1	Salt Lake City Salt Lake City-Murray	A+	75.4	3.5%	+4.6%	+3.2%	+1.1%	57 days
2	Raleigh Raleigh-Cary	A+	75.1	3.2%	+3.4%	+2.1%	+0.5%	59 days
3	Cincinnati Cincinnati	A+	75.0	3.7%	+7.2%	+1.0%	-0.2%	42 days
4	Hartford Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A+	70.4	2.7%	+5.2%	+1.9%	+2.8%	36 days
5	Kansas City Kansas City	A+	69.3	3.8%	+7.4%	+0.7%	+0.3%	50 days
6	St. Louis St. Louis	A	66.0	3.8%	+2.8%	+0.5%	+0.5%	45 days
7	Charlotte Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	A	63.8	3.7%	+4.1%	+1.4%	-0.7%	61 days
8	Austin Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A-	62.6	4.0%	+4.8%	+1.7%	+0.8%	73 days
9	Philadelphia Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	A-	61.7	4.2%	+1.5%	+0.7%	+1.4%	48 days
10	Pittsburgh Pittsburgh	A-	61.1	3.7%	+4.5%	-0.0%	+1.6%	53 days
11	Nashville Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A-	60.3	3.1%	+4.7%	+1.6%	-0.9%	60 days
12	Memphis Memphis	A-	60.2	4.7%	+6.6%	+0.1%	-0.9%	68 days
13	Dallas Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	A-	60.0	4.6%	+3.4%	+1.3%	+0.8%	58 days
14	Las Vegas Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	A-	59.6	5.4%	+4.0%	+1.4%	+1.0%	58 days
15	Orlando Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	B+	57.2	4.7%	+5.8%	+1.1%	+0.2%	75 days
16	San Jose San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	B	54.7	4.1%	+0.5%	+1.3%	-0.5%	36 days
17	New York New York Newark-Jersey City	B	52.9	4.3%	+1.9%	+1.0%	+0.6%	56 days
18	Seattle Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B	52.3	5.0%	+5.8%	+0.8%	-0.8%	45 days
19	Atlanta Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	B	52.0	3.2%	+3.0%	-0.1%	+0.9%	59 days
20	Baltimore Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	B	51.3	4.2%	+4.9%	-0.1%	-0.0%	44 days
21	Tampa Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B	51.2	4.8%	+5.3%	+0.6%	-0.5%	74 days
22	Columbus Columbus	B	50.3	3.2%	+3.3%	+0.0%	-1.4%	44 days
23	Houston Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B-	49.2	5.1%	+1.7%	+1.5%	+0.3%	52 days
24	Miami Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	B-	49.1	3.7%	+7.0%	+0.5%	-0.2%	85 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
25	Washington DC Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	B-	47.5	4.0%	+5.3%	-2.1%	-2.2%	43 days
26	Oklahoma City Oklahoma City	B-	47.4	4.3%	+4.9%	+0.4%	-0.5%	55 days
27	Los Angeles Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B-	47.3	5.0%	+3.5%	+1.8%	-2.2%	53 days
28	Cleveland Cleveland	B-	47.1	3.4%	+0.1%	+0.6%	+1.8%	55 days
29	San Francisco San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	B-	45.7	4.4%	+6.0%	+0.2%	-1.7%	38 days
30	Birmingham Birmingham	B-	45.4	3.5%	+0.6%	+0.7%	-1.1%	59 days
31	Providence Providence-Warwick	C+	44.0	4.3%	+2.8%	+0.6%	+1.7%	39 days
32	Boston Boston-Cambridge-Newton	C+	43.7	3.9%	+2.9%	+0.3%	+2.9%	51 days
33	Denver Denver-Aurora-Centennial	C+	43.5	4.1%	+1.9%	+0.3%	-1.7%	57 days
34	Fresno Fresno	C+	42.9	7.7%	+5.1%	+2.5%	-1.4%	57 days
35	Virginia Beach Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C+	42.3	3.9%	+5.5%	-0.7%	-0.9%	40 days
36	Phoenix Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	C+	42.1	4.8%	+2.6%	+1.2%	-2.7%	67 days
37	San Antonio San Antonio-New Braunfels	C+	39.5	4.7%	+2.2%	+0.8%	+0.1%	68 days
38	Portland Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C+	39.4	4.9%	+5.3%	-1.4%	-0.6%	61 days
39	Milwaukee Milwaukee-Waukesha	C+	39.4	3.8%	+1.5%	-0.1%	+0.8%	36 days
40	San Diego San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	C	37.5	4.7%	+6.7%	+0.5%	-1.8%	45 days
41	Riverside Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C	36.2	5.7%	+6.0%	+0.8%	-1.8%	63 days
42	Minneapolis Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C	35.4	4.4%	-0.1%	+1.4%	-1.3%	39 days
43	Indianapolis Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C-	31.6	3.4%	+0.1%	-1.2%	-1.0%	51 days
44	Grand Rapids Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	C-	31.6	4.3%	+1.8%	+0.5%	-7.5%	38 days
45	Richmond Richmond	C-	30.9	3.8%	+2.5%	-0.8%	-0.9%	44 days
46	Jacksonville Jacksonville	C-	28.5	4.9%	+0.4%	+0.4%	-0.3%	65 days
47	Louisville Louisville-Jefferson County	C-	27.8	4.8%	+1.6%	-0.1%	+0.2%	44 days
48	Sacramento Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	C-	27.7	5.0%	+1.1%	+0.3%	-1.9%	50 days
49	Detroit Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	C-	27.4	6.0%	+0.6%	+0.2%	+0.7%	40 days
50	Chicago Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C-	27.2	4.9%	+3.1%	+0.2%	-2.5%	36 days

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

A+

EXCELLENT

75.4th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area boasts an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 75.4th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a top-tier ranking in the 96th percentile, driven by a 3.20% year-over-year employment growth rate and a weekly hours deviation of -0.796% from its own trend. The combination of strong employment growth and slightly below-trend hours worked suggests genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has experienced a 3.20% year-over-year employment growth rate, coupled with a -0.796% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs at a rapid pace while hours worked are slightly below trend. The labor demand composite score of 7.70 ranks in the top tier, at the 96th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Salt Lake City-Murray stands at 3.50%, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as well as upward pressure on wages. With a lower unemployment rate, the city's labor market has less slack, making it more competitive for employers to attract talent.

Wage Growth

The city has experienced a year-over-year wage growth rate of 4.60%, ranking in the 60th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable pace. As a result, workers in the area are seeing an increase in their purchasing power, which can have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$263/sqft to \$39.49/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.66, Salt Lake City-Murray ranks in the 55th percentile in terms of affordability. This near-median ranking indicates that the city is neither extremely affordable nor excessively expensive compared to its peers. The relatively stable cost of living means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Salt Lake City-Murray has grown by 1.13% year-over-year, ranking in the 86th percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing businesses with a growing pool of potential employees. As the labor force continues to grow, hiring capacity is likely to remain robust.

Building Permits

The city has seen a 40.08% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking in the 88th percentile. This significant rise in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce. The increase in building permits is a positive signal for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Salt Lake City-Murray currently stands at 57 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 1.7%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, ranking in the 22nd percentile, indicates a competitive market that may be challenging for relocating workers. The swift movement of homes in this market can make it difficult for newcomers to find and secure housing.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share of 4.32, ranking in the 96th percentile, Salt Lake City-Murray boasts a deep and talented pool of professional workers. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, it may be less suited for industries with primarily industrial or logistics-based workforces.

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, moderate wage growth, and an expanding workforce, making it an excellent location for companies looking to grow and attract talent. However, the relatively tight labor market and competitive housing market may pose challenges for businesses trying to hire and relocate workers, and these factors should be carefully considered in any location decision.

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

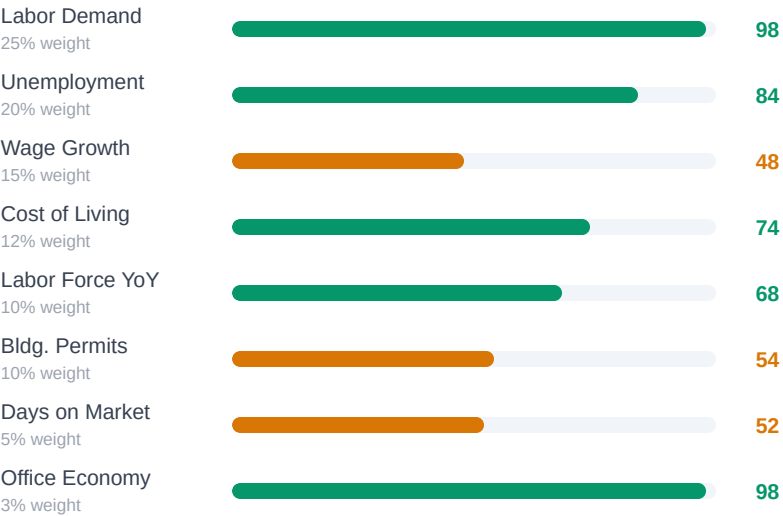
A+

EXCELLENT

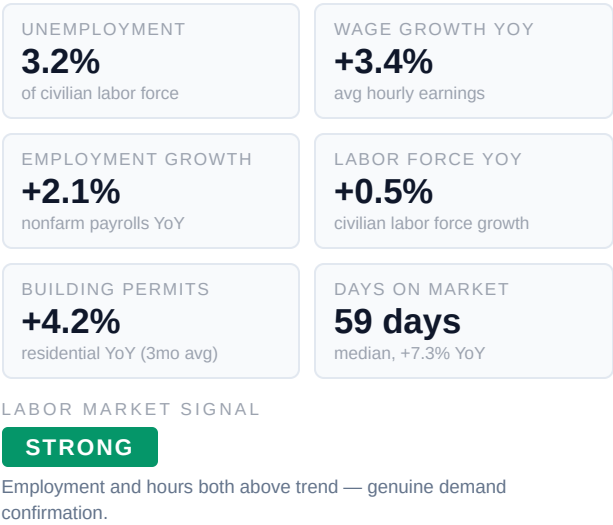
75.1th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 75.1th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score in the 98th percentile, and its strong office economy, also in the 98th percentile, with 4.48 out of 5 score in professional/office worker share. The labor demand is driven by a 2.07% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.137% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The Raleigh-Cary metro area is experiencing genuine demand expansion, with a 2.07% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.137% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals a strong and growing job market, where hours are increasing alongside employment, indicating that businesses are not only hiring but also utilizing their workforce more intensely. The labor demand composite score of 8.33 places it in the top tier, at the 98th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Raleigh-Cary stands at 3.20%, which is in the top tier, ranking at the 84th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with less slack, making it harder for businesses to hire due to increased competition for available workers. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Raleigh-Cary is 3.43%, placing it near the median at the 48th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but not at an alarming rate, while workers benefit from a modest increase in purchasing power. However, the relatively moderate pace of wage growth may not significantly erode profit margins for businesses.

Cost of Living

Raleigh-Cary has a cost of living score that ranks in the 74th percentile, indicating it is more affordable than many of its peer cities, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$215/sqft to \$37.64/hr, which is 5.71. The fact that PSF is falling by 2.3% year-over-year relative to wages enhances the city's affordability. This makes it an attractive location for talent, as businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Raleigh-Cary is growing at a rate of 0.48% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking at the 68th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, albeit slowly, providing a slightly increasing pool of potential hires for

businesses. However, the growth rate is not exceptionally high, which may limit the rapid expansion of businesses reliant on a rapidly growing labor force.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is 4.15%, placing it near the median at the 54th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is slowly expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce over time. However, the moderate pace of permit issuance may not rapidly alleviate any existing housing supply constraints.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Raleigh-Cary is 59 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.3%, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile. This indicates a moderately competitive market that is becoming slightly less heated over time. For workers relocating to this city, the market is neither extremely competitive nor very accessible, offering a relatively balanced environment for homebuyers.

Office Economy

Raleigh-Cary boasts a deep professional talent pool, with its office economy ranking in the 98th percentile. This makes the city highly suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations that require specialized knowledge workers. Conversely, it may be less ideal for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant, which require different skill sets.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, a deep professional talent pool, and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for a variety of industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the relatively tight labor market, which may lead to increased competition for talent and upward pressure on wages, potentially affecting business operational costs and profitability.

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

A+

EXCELLENT

75.0th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		48
Unemployment 20% weight		94
Wage Growth 15% weight		96
Cost of Living 12% weight		88
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		54
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		76
Days on Market 5% weight		98
Office Economy 3% weight		44

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.7% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +7.2% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.0% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.2% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +24.8% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 42 days median, +13.5% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking at the 75.0th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.70% and strong wage growth of +7.22% year-over-year, indicating a tight labor market with rising labor costs. These metrics suggest that Cincinnati is an attractive location for businesses seeking a skilled workforce, but may also pose challenges for hiring and talent retention.

Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate is +0.97% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.372% below trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 5.29, which ranks near the median at the 48th percentile. This combination signals a moderate expansion of genuine demand, as hours are slightly below trend despite job growth. The labor market is growing, but not at a pace that would indicate a significant surge in demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cincinnati is 3.70%, ranking at the 94th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have strong bargaining power, which could drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cincinnati is +7.22% year-over-year, ranking at the 96th percentile, indicating fast-rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as employees have more disposable income to spend on goods and services. However, it also means that businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, which could impact profitability.

Cost of Living

Cincinnati has a cost of living score that ranks at the 88th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$191/sqft to \$35.56/hr, or 5.37, and a year-over-year decrease in PSF of -0.5%. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The affordable cost of living could be a major draw for businesses looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cincinnati is growing at a rate of -0.21% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile, indicating a slight contraction in the labor pool. This means that the supply of workers is not expanding, which could pose a structural headwind for hiring and business growth. Businesses may need to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Cincinnati is increasing by +24.76% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 76th percentile, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This suggests that the city is experiencing developer confidence, and future housing supply is likely to increase, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Cincinnati is 42 days, with a year-over-year increase of +13.5%, ranking at the 98th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, this could also signal a normalization of the market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

Cincinnati's office economy ranks near the median at the 44th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 2.28. This suggests that the city has a moderate-sized talent pool, suited for businesses that require a mix of office and industrial skills. While it may not be the best location for tech or finance companies, it could be an attractive location for businesses with more diversified workforce needs.

Cincinnati offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, strong wage growth, and relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies seeking to relocate or expand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential challenge of hiring and retaining talent in a market with low unemployment and rising labor costs, which could impact business growth and profitability.

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

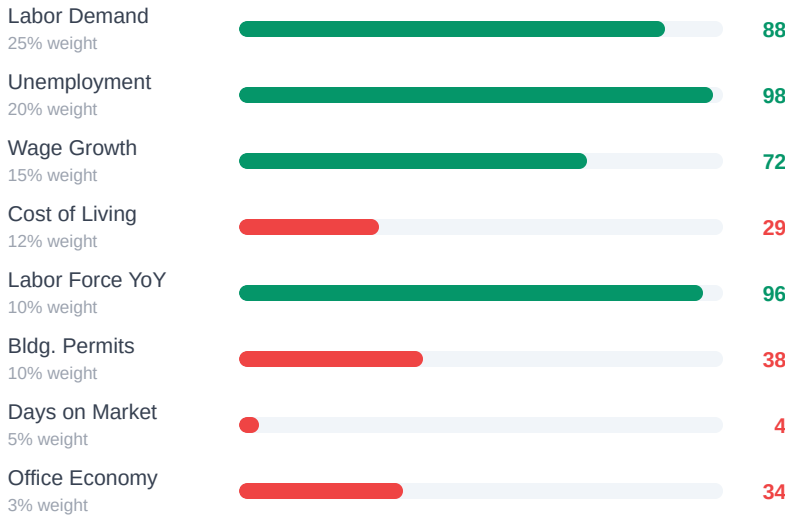
A+

EXCELLENT

70.4th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

2.7%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.2%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.9%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+2.8%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-7.6%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

36 days

median, -5.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 70.4th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at 88th percentile, and its extremely low unemployment rate of 2.70%, ranking it in the top tier at 98th percentile. The combination of these two metrics signals a highly competitive job market with strong demand for labor.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 1.88% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by -0.321%, still indicating a top-tier labor demand composite score of 88th percentile. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs while hours worked are slightly below trend, suggesting that the growth is not solely due to existing workers taking on more hours. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 2.70%, which is extremely low and ranks in the top tier at 98th percentile. This indicates a very tight labor market with little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain top talent in this competitive job market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 5.21%, which is above average and ranks in the 72nd percentile. This moderate to fast wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local businesses that rely on consumer spending.

Cost of Living

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has a cost of living ratio of \$251 per square foot to \$39.67 per hour, resulting in a below-average affordability score of 29th percentile. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. However, the fact that the PSF is rising by 3.3% year-over-year while wages are also growing may help to mitigate some of the affordability concerns.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is growing at a rate of 2.77% year-over-year, which is in the top tier at 96th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing a positive environment for businesses looking to hire and grow.

their operations. The increasing labor force can help to alleviate some of the pressure on wages and provide a more sustainable hiring environment.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has decreased by 7.56% year-over-year, ranking in the 38th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply may be tightening, which could lead to future affordability concerns and make it more challenging for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is currently 36 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 5.3%. This rapid pace of home sales indicates a highly competitive and fast-paced market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. The low days on market percentile rank of 4th percentile suggests that the market is extremely hot, and buyers may need to act quickly to secure a property.

Office Economy

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has a professional and office worker share of 2.08, ranking in the 34th percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making it less suited for businesses that rely heavily on tech, finance, or consulting expertise. However, the city may be more attractive to businesses in other industries, such as logistics or manufacturing, that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

In conclusion, Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford offers businesses a highly competitive labor market with strong demand and low unemployment, but also presents challenges such as a tight labor market and rising labor costs. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this area is the potential for affordability concerns and housing supply constraints, which could impact their ability to attract and retain top talent.

Kansas City

Kansas City

A+

EXCELLENT

69.3th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		66
25% weight		
Unemployment		78
20% weight		
Wage Growth		98
15% weight		
Cost of Living		80
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		66
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		44
10% weight		
Days on Market		28
5% weight		
Office Economy		18
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.8% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +7.4% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.7% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.3% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -5.6% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 50 days median, 0.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 69.3th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 7.38%, and its low unemployment rate of 3.80%, which signals a tight labor market. These metrics suggest a city with a high demand for labor and rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

Kansas City's employment growth rate is 0.69% year-over-year, combined with a 0.321% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a real increase in labor demand, with both more jobs being added and existing workers putting in more hours. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the city.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Kansas City is 3.80%, which is relatively low and indicates a tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. However, this also suggests that the local consumer demand is strong, which can be beneficial for businesses.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Kansas City is 7.38%, which is a fast pace and indicates rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as employees have more disposable income to spend on goods and services. However, it also means that businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs in the future.

Cost of Living

Kansas City has a cost of living score that ranks it in the 80th percentile, meaning it is more affordable than most of its peer cities. The city's price-to-salary ratio is \$196/sqft vs \$36.13/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.42. This affordability makes it an attractive location for talent, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring large wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Kansas City is growing at a rate of 0.34% year-over-year, indicating that the supply of workers is expanding. This growth in the labor force is a positive sign for businesses, as it suggests that there will be a larger pool of potential employees to hire from in the future.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Kansas City has decreased by 5.58% year-over-year, which may indicate a tightening of the housing supply. This decrease in permits could signal future affordability challenges and make it more difficult for workers to find housing, potentially impacting the city's ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Kansas City is 50 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast pace of home sales suggests that the housing market is competitive, and relocating workers may face challenges in finding available homes. However, the stable days on market also indicates a balanced market, which can be beneficial for businesses looking to establish operations in the city.

Office Economy

Kansas City's professional and office worker share ranks in the 18th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city may not be the best fit for businesses that require a deep pool of specialized office or professional talent, such as tech or finance companies. However, it may be more suitable for industries with different labor requirements, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers businesses a strong labor market with rising wages and low unemployment, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand or establish operations. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the potential tightening of the housing supply, which could impact the city's ability to attract and retain talent in the future.

St. Louis

St. Louis

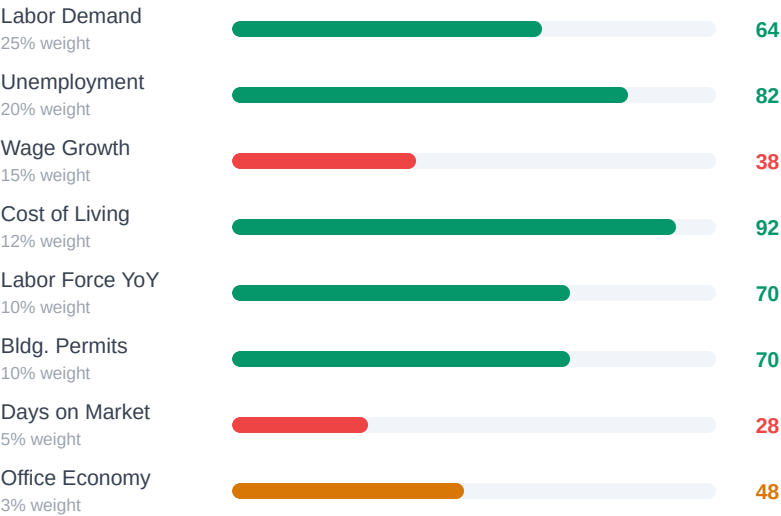
A

VERY GOOD

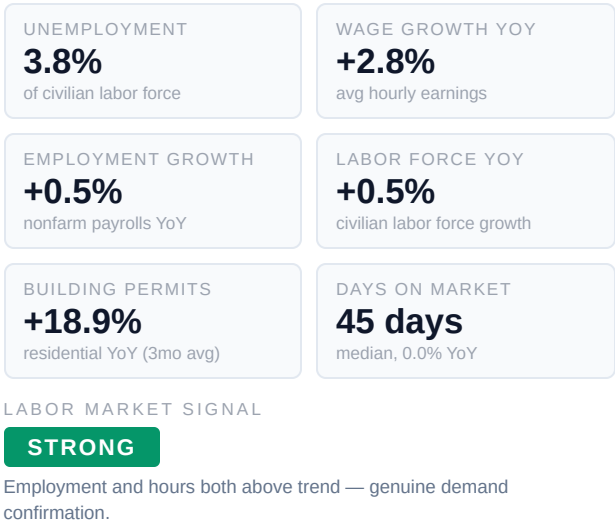
66.0th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis earns an overall grade of A, ranking in the 66.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and highly affordable cost of living. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.58, combining a +0.49% employment growth rate and a +0.598% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with its top-tier cost of living percentile rank of 92, makes St. Louis an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Demand

St. Louis exhibits a +0.49% employment growth rate and a +0.598% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicating a genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, pointing to a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.58 further reinforces this, ranking in the 64th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in St. Louis stands at 3.80%, placing it in the top tier with an 82nd percentile rank. This tight labor market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the low unemployment rate translates to higher competition for available talent and potential upward pressure on wages. For a business trying to hire in St. Louis, this means being prepared to offer competitive compensation packages.

Wage Growth

St. Louis experiences a year-over-year wage growth rate of +2.84%, which ranks in the 38th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. While this is below the national average, it still suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, albeit at a slower pace. This moderate wage growth supports worker purchasing power without overly inflating labor costs for businesses.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 92, St. Louis is highly affordable, boasting a PSF of \$164/sqft that has decreased by 1.2% year-over-year, coupled with an average hourly earnings of \$37.84. This affordability advantage means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs, making it an attractive location for companies looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in St. Louis is growing at a rate of +0.54% year-over-year, ranking in the 70th percentile. This expansion in the labor force supply indicates that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, which is beneficial for businesses looking to hire. The positive growth rate suggests that St. Louis can support the hiring needs of expanding businesses.

Building Permits

St. Louis has seen an 18.86% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, placing it in the 70th percentile. This significant rise in permits signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The increase in building permits is a positive indicator for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

Homes in St. Louis currently sit on the market for a median of 45 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%. This relatively fast market, ranking in the 28th percentile, means that relocating workers may face a competitive environment when searching for housing. However, the stable days on market suggest a balanced housing market that is neither overly hot nor cold.

Office Economy

St. Louis has a professional and office worker share that places it near the median, with a 48th percentile rank. This indicates a moderately deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, although it may not be as robust as in other major metropolitan areas. The city is well-suited for a variety of businesses but may not offer the same level of specialized talent as larger, more knowledge-economy dominant metros.

In conclusion, St. Louis offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, highly affordable cost of living, and a growing labor force, making it an attractive location for relocation or expansion. However, the tight labor market and moderate wage growth rate pose challenges for hiring and labor costs, which decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating St. Louis as a potential business location.

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

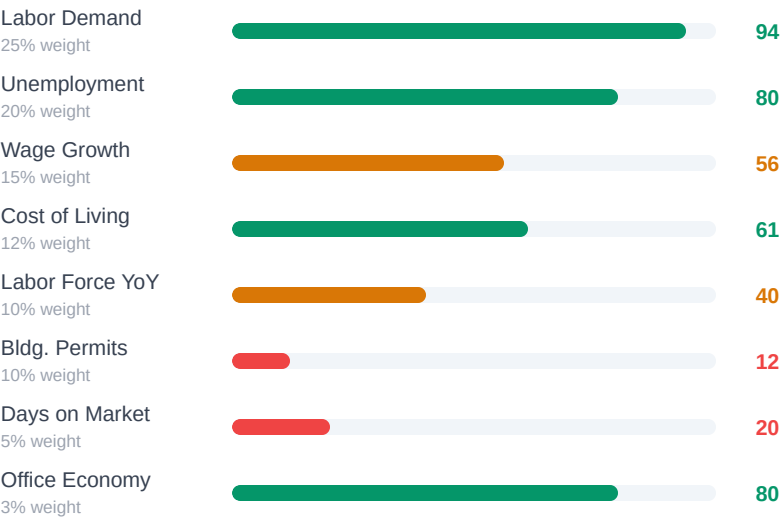
A

VERY GOOD

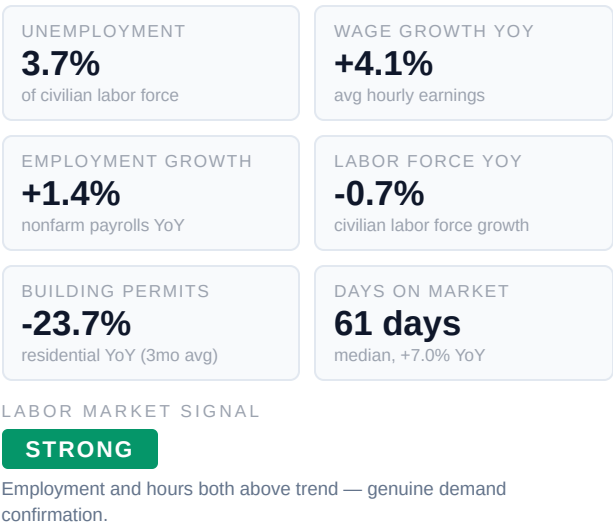
63.8th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 63.8th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and low unemployment rate being the two metrics that most define its current economic character, at 94th and 80th percentiles, respectively. The labor demand composite score of 7.35, driven by a 1.36% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.141% deviation in weekly hours above trend, signals a genuine demand expansion. This combination of metrics suggests a city with a thriving job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.36% and weekly hours deviation of 1.141% above trend indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 7.35, at the 94th percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.70% is relatively low, ranking in the 80th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 4.14% is moderate, ranking in the 56th percentile, indicating that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. This rate of wage growth suggests that workers are seeing some improvement in their purchasing power, but it is not overly inflationary. Employers can expect to see some upward pressure on wages, but it is manageable.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia, with a PSF of \$218/sqft and an earnings ratio of \$37.80/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.77, ranks in the 61st percentile, indicating a relatively affordable city. The fact that PSF is falling by 0.9% year-over-year further enhances the city's affordability. This means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The year-over-year growth rate of the civilian labor force is -0.70%, ranking in the 40th percentile, indicating a contracting labor pool. This suggests that the supply of workers is shrinking, which could create structural headwinds for hiring and business expansion. Businesses may need to be more competitive in their hiring practices to attract the available talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -23.67%, ranking in the 12th percentile, indicating a significant tightening of housing supply. This suggests that the city may face future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation, which could impact businesses' ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 61 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.0%, ranking in the 20th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, which could make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city to find housing. However, the rising days on market could also signal a normalization of the market after a period of rapid growth.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 3.36, ranking in the 80th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers, but may be less suitable for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with low unemployment and a deep talent pool, making it an attractive location for companies in the professional and office sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the tightening housing supply, which could lead to future affordability challenges and impact the city's ability to attract and retain talent.

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

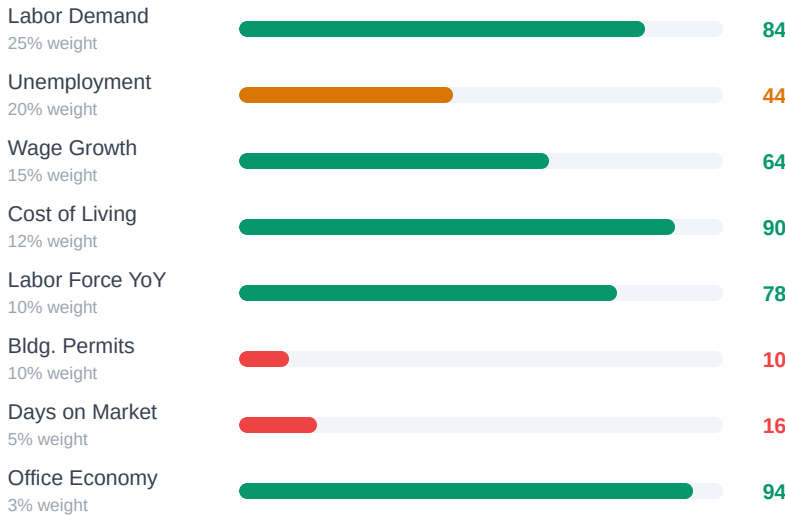
A-

GOOD

62.6th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+4.8%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.7%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+0.8%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-29.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

73 days

median, +1.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 62.6th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 84th percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 90th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a robust job market and attractive living costs.

Labor Demand

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has an employment growth rate of +1.70% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of -0.262% from its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 6.42. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs and hours are running slightly below trend, indicating a healthy and sustainable labor market. The top-tier percentile rank of 84th confirms the city's strong labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 4.00%, ranking at the 44th percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This suggests that the market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to cities with tighter labor markets. However, the unemployment rate is not so low that it would drive up wage pressure significantly.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is +4.80%, ranking above average at the 64th percentile. This moderate to fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive in the market.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$231/sqft to \$37.54/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.15, and a year-over-year decrease of -8.0% in PSF, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is highly affordable, ranking at the 90th percentile. This makes the city an attractive location for talent, as workers can enjoy a relatively low cost of living without requiring significant wage premiums. The falling PSF is a key driver of the high affordability score.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is growing at a rate of +0.80% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 78th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing a positive implication for hiring capacity and the ability of businesses to find skilled workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -29.04%, ranking at the 10th percentile, indicating a significant tightening of housing supply. This signals a potential future affordability issue and a challenge for workforce accommodation, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 73 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.4%. This ranks at the 16th percentile, indicating a slower market. For workers relocating to this city, the relatively slower pace of home sales may make it more accessible to find a home, but it also suggests a less competitive market.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share of 4.22, ranking at the 94th percentile, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in these sectors, but less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented economies.

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

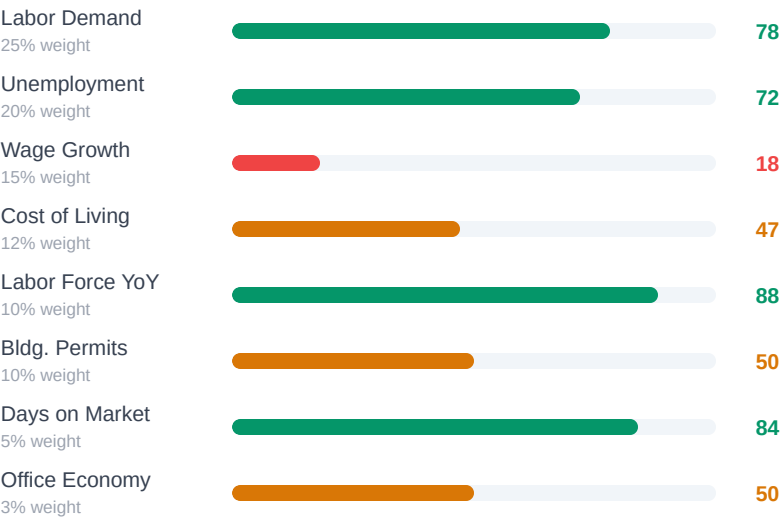
A-

GOOD

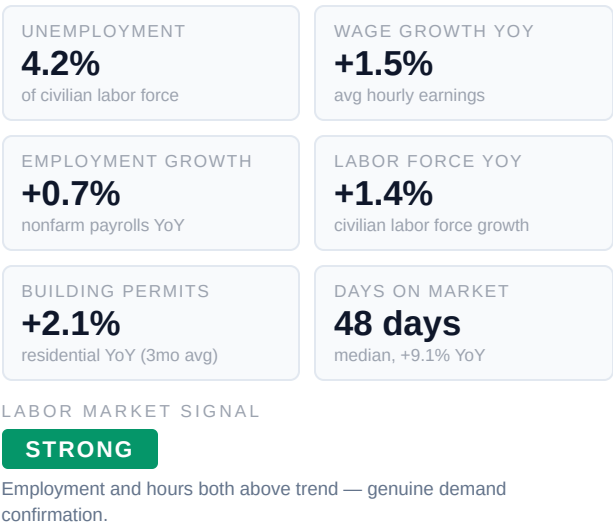
61.7th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 61.7th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score at the 78th percentile, and its moderate cost of living, ranked at the 47th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a combination of employment growth and hours worked above trend, signaling genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The city's employment growth rate is 0.74% year-over-year, and weekly hours are 0.922% above the 12-month baseline, indicating a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a positive sign for businesses looking to expand. The labor demand composite score of 6.26 further reinforces this trend, ranking above average at the 78th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is 4.20%, ranking above average at the 72nd percentile, which means the market has some slack but is still relatively tight. This rate implies that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, businesses may still face some competition for top talent, and wage pressure could be a concern. However, the relatively low unemployment rate suggests that the local consumer demand is likely to be stable.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the city is 1.51%, which is relatively slow, ranking at the 18th percentile. This slow wage growth implies that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing quickly. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have as much disposable income to spend.

Cost of Living

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has a cost of living ranked at the 47th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$228/sqft to \$32.62/hr, or 6.99. The city's cost of living is near the median, making it neither extremely affordable nor expensive. The fact that the PSF is falling by 0.9% year-over-year is a positive sign for affordability. This means that the city can attract talent without necessarily requiring significant wage premiums, as the cost of living is relatively manageable.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the city is growing at a rate of 1.42% year-over-year, which is a top-tier growth rate, ranking at the 88th percentile. This expansion in the labor force supply implies that businesses have a growing pool of potential workers to hire from, making it

easier to find talent. The increasing labor force also suggests that the city is likely to continue attracting new workers and businesses.

Building Permits

The city has seen a 2.10% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This moderate growth in permits suggests that the housing supply is slowly expanding, which could help improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. However, the relatively modest growth rate may not be enough to keep up with demand, potentially leading to some affordability challenges in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is 48 days, with a 9.1% year-over-year increase, ranking at the 84th percentile. This means that homes are sitting on the market for a relatively long time, indicating a slower market that is more accessible to relocating workers. The rising days on market suggests that the housing market is normalizing, making it easier for workers to find and purchase homes.

Office Economy

The city has an office economy ranked at the 50th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 2.52 out of 5. This indicates a moderately deep talent pool, suitable for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but not exceptionally strong. The city is well-suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and non-professional workers, but may not be the best fit for those requiring extremely specialized or high-end talent.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a moderate cost of living, and a growing labor force. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the potential for affordability challenges in the future, driven by modest growth in housing supply. Overall, the city presents a compelling opportunity for businesses looking to expand or relocate, with a relatively stable and growing economy.

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

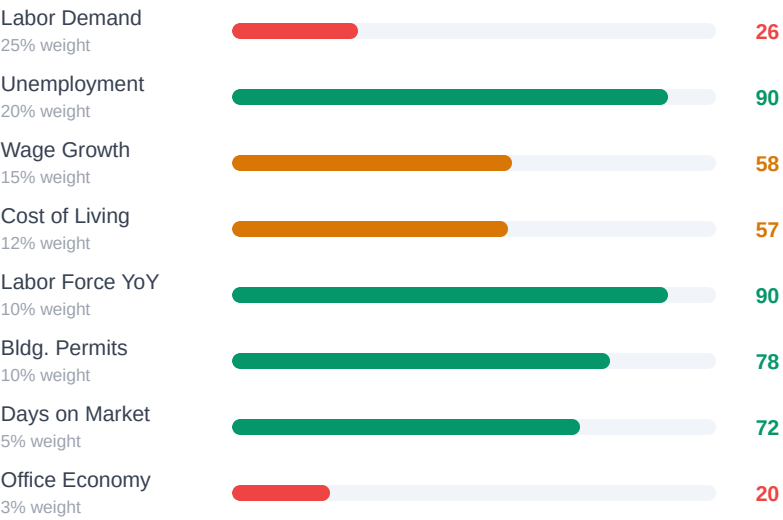
A-

GOOD

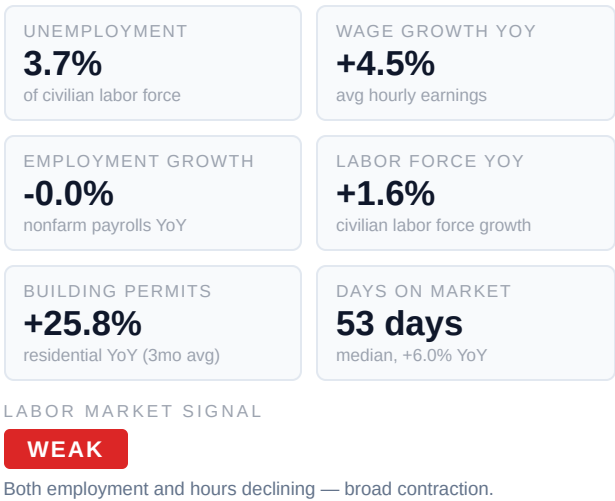
61.1th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 61.1th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.70% and its labor force growth rate of +1.61% YoY, indicating a tight labor market with an expanding workforce. These metrics suggest a city with a strong foundation for business growth, but also potential challenges in hiring and retaining talent.

Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's employment growth rate is -0.02% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating -0.470% from its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.27, which ranks below average at the 26th percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The negative employment growth rate indicates a decrease in job openings, which may affect businesses looking to expand their operations.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 3.70%, ranking it at the 90th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring and retaining talent, as the low unemployment rate puts upward pressure on wages. With such a tight market, companies may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract and retain employees.

Wage Growth

Pittsburgh's wage growth rate is +4.48% YoY, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. As a result, workers in Pittsburgh are experiencing an increase in purchasing power, which can have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Pittsburgh's cost of living, with a PSF of \$172/sqft and an hourly wage of \$33.21, resulting in a ratio of 5.18, ranks near the median at the 57th percentile. This means that the city is neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. The stable YoY change in PSF (+0.0%) suggests that the cost of living is not increasing significantly, making it easier for businesses to attract talent without needing to offer large wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of +1.61% YoY, ranking it at the 90th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing businesses with a growing pool of potential employees. As the labor force continues to grow, companies may find it easier to hire and staff their operations.

Building Permits

Pittsburgh has seen a +25.84% YoY increase in building permits, ranking it above average at the 78th percentile. This significant increase in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. As a result, businesses can expect a more stable and affordable housing market for their employees.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Pittsburgh is 53 days, with a +6.0% YoY increase, ranking it above average at the 72nd percentile. This means that homes are sitting on the market for a relatively longer period, making it a more accessible market for workers relocating to the city. The rising DOM indicates a healthy normalization of the market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

Pittsburgh's office economy, with a professional worker share ranking at the 20th percentile, indicates a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, it may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, moderate wage growth, and an expanding workforce, making it an attractive location for companies looking to grow. However, the biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential challenge in hiring and retaining talent due to the low unemployment rate, which may require companies to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract and retain employees.

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

A-

GOOD

60.3th percentile

Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		72
Unemployment 20% weight		92
Wage Growth 15% weight		62
Cost of Living 12% weight		51
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		30
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		14
Days on Market 5% weight		28
Office Economy 3% weight		88

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.1% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +4.7% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.6% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.9% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -21.9% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 60 days median, +1.7% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 60.3th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.10% and its above-average labor demand composite score of 6.06, which combines a +1.56% employment growth rate with a -0.424% weekly hours deviation from its own trend. These metrics suggest a city with a strong job market and genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +1.56% and weekly hours deviation of -0.424% indicate a city with genuine demand expansion, as hours are running slightly below trend during a period of job growth. This combination signals that the labor market is experiencing real growth, rather than just a survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 6.06 ranks in the 72nd percentile, confirming the city's above-average labor market performance.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.10% ranks in the 92nd percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin may face challenges in finding available workers, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have significant bargaining power in the job market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +4.66% ranks in the 62nd percentile, indicating moderate to fast wage growth. This implies that employer labor costs are rising, but workers are also experiencing increased purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but can also expect to benefit from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin, with a PSF of \$259/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.38/hr, results in a ratio of 7.32, ranking in the 51st percentile. This means that the city is near the median in terms of affordability, neither particularly expensive nor unusually affordable. As a result, businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent, but may still face some competition for workers.

Labor Force Growth

The year-over-year growth rate of the civilian labor force is -0.95%, ranking in the 30th percentile, indicating a contracting labor pool. This suggests that the supply of workers is shrinking, which may create structural headwinds for hiring and business expansion in the city.

Businesses may need to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent in this environment.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -21.89%, ranking in the 14th percentile, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply. This signals that the city may be facing a future affordability crisis and workforce accommodation challenges, as the supply of housing is not keeping pace with demand. Businesses may need to consider the potential impact of rising housing costs on their employees' quality of life and affordability.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 60 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.7%. This suggests that the housing market is slowing down, with homes taking slightly longer to sell than in the past. For workers relocating to the city, this may make it easier to find a home, as the market is becoming less competitive.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors is 3.86, ranking in the 88th percentile, indicating a deep and talented pool of knowledge workers. This makes Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

In conclusion, Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin offers businesses a strong job market with genuine demand expansion, a talented pool of knowledge workers, and a moderate cost of living. However, the city's low unemployment rate and shrinking labor pool also pose significant challenges for hiring and business expansion, making it essential for decision-makers to carefully consider these factors when evaluating the city as a potential location.

Memphis

Memphis

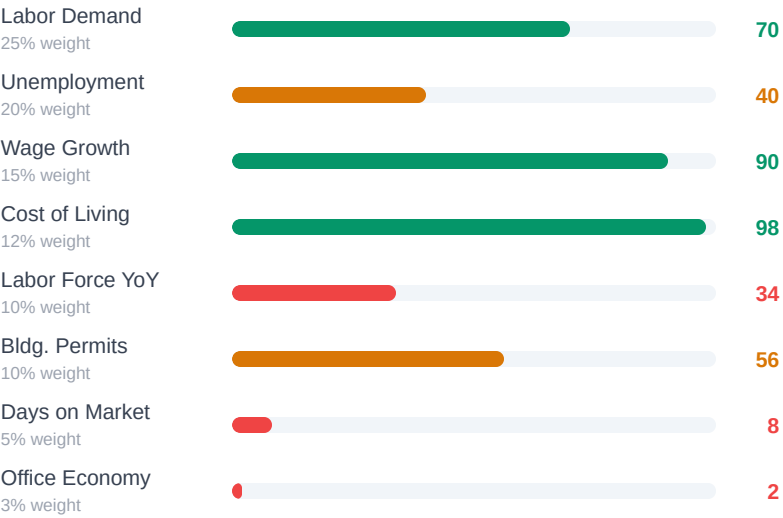
A-

GOOD

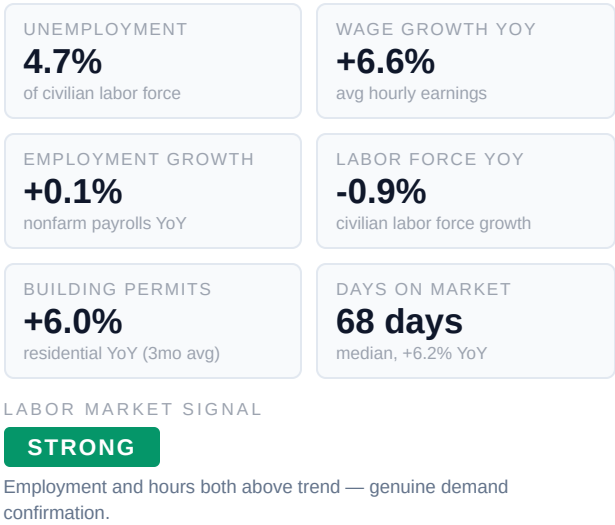
60.2th percentile

Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 60.2th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.63%, and its highly affordable cost of living, with a PSF to earnings ratio of 4.67, ranking it in the top tier at the 98th percentile. These two metrics suggest a city with a competitive labor market and attractive living conditions.

Labor Demand

Memphis has experienced employment growth of 0.06% year-over-year, combined with a 1.422% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a healthy and growing labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.81 ranks in the 70th percentile, further supporting the notion of a strong labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Memphis stands at 4.70%, ranking it near the median at the 40th percentile. This rate suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to cities with tighter labor markets. However, this also implies that local consumer demand may be somewhat weaker due to the availability of labor.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 6.63%, Memphis is experiencing fast wage growth, ranking it in the top tier at the 90th percentile. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also indicates strong worker purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local businesses relying on consumer spending.

Cost of Living

Memphis is highly affordable, with a cost of living ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile. The city's PSF to earnings ratio is 4.67, with PSF at \$153/sqft and earnings at \$32.74/hr, and this ratio is becoming even more favorable due to a 4.4% year-over-year decrease in PSF. This affordability makes Memphis an attractive location for talent without the need for significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Memphis has contracted by 0.92% year-over-year, ranking it below average at the 34th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face challenges in finding sufficient skilled workers to meet their needs.

Building Permits

Memphis has seen a 5.95% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking it near the median at the 56th percentile. This expansion in housing supply suggests that developer confidence is present, and future affordability and workforce accommodation are likely to improve, making the city more attractive for relocating workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Memphis is 68 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.2%, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market where homes do not stay on the market for long, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing.

Office Economy

Memphis has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with different skill requirements, like logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Memphis offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, highly affordable living conditions, and a relatively slack labor market, making it an attractive location for certain types of industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the contracting labor force supply, which may pose challenges in finding and retaining skilled workers, potentially limiting the city's long-term growth potential.

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

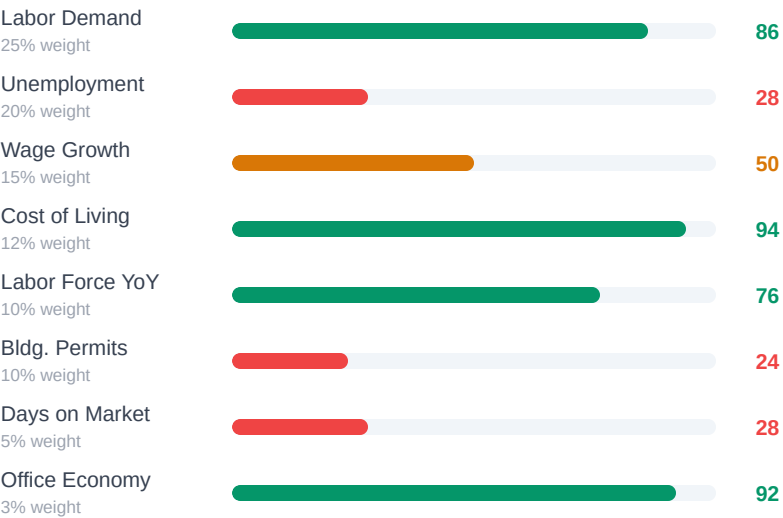
A-

GOOD

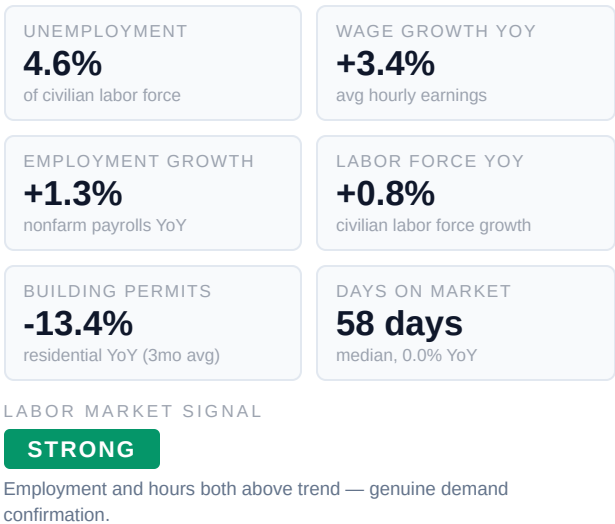
60.0th percentile

Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 60.0th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 86th percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 94th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a combination of employment growth and hours worked above trend.

Labor Demand

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has seen employment growth of 1.26% year-over-year, combined with a 0.463% deviation in weekly hours above its own 12-month trend. This signals genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing, indicating a strong and growing labor market. The combination of these metrics suggests that businesses can expect to find a talented and available workforce.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 4.60%, ranking at the 28th percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it relatively easier to hire workers, as there is a pool of available labor. However, the relatively high unemployment rate also suggests that local consumer demand may be weaker than in tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in the metro area is 3.44% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers are seeing their purchasing power increase, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is highly affordable, with a percentile rank of 94, driven by a PSF of \$199/sqft that is falling 2.0% year-over-year relative to wages of \$38.32/hr. This affordability advantage means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for companies looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the metro area is growing at a rate of 0.79% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 76th percentile. This expanding labor force supply suggests that businesses will have a growing pool of potential workers to draw from, making it easier to hire and staff new positions.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has decreased by 13.44% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 24th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability challenges and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the metro area is 58 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast market means that workers relocating to the area may face competition for available housing, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent from other locations.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is ranked at the 92nd percentile, indicating a deep and talented pool of knowledge-economy workers. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industries with primarily industrial or logistics roles.

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, affordable cost of living, and a deep talent pool, making it an attractive location for companies looking to relocate or expand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which could lead to future affordability challenges and make it more difficult to attract and retain talent.

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

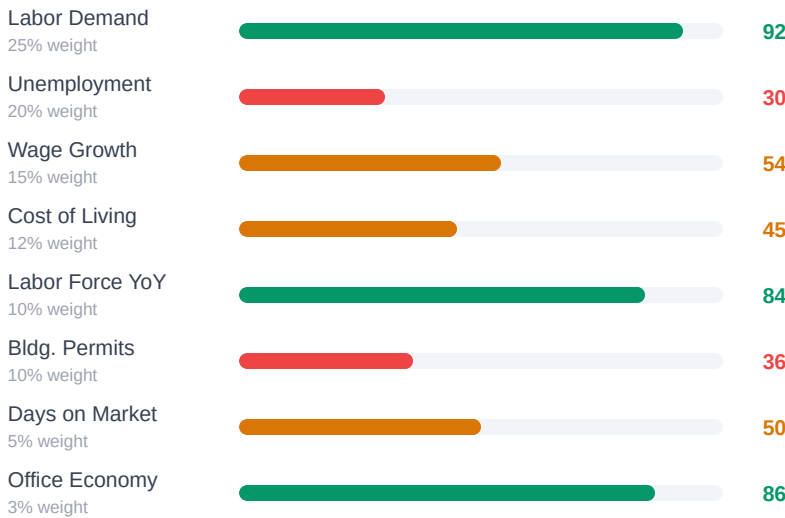
A-

GOOD

59.6th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

5.4%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+4.0%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.4%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+1.0%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-9.8%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

58 days
median, +3.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 59.6th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 92nd percentile, and its moderate cost of living, ranked at the 45th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a combination of employment growth and hours worked above trend.

Labor Demand

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has seen employment growth of 1.42% year-over-year, combined with weekly hours 0.733% above its own 12-month trend. This signals genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing, indicating a strong and growing labor market. The labor demand composite score of 7.02 is in the top tier, at the 92nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 5.40%, which ranks at the 30th percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This means that while it may not be as challenging to hire as in tighter markets, there is still a notable pool of potential employees available. For a business trying to hire, this suggests a relatively balanced environment, neither extremely competitive nor overly loose.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the metro area is 3.95%, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing at a steady pace. This balance is likely to support both business operations and local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$261/sqft to \$32.65/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.99, and a percentile rank of 45, Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is near the median in terms of affordability. The fact that PSF is falling by 1.9% year-over-year relative to wages indicates a trend towards greater affordability. This means the city has a moderate talent attraction advantage without needing significant wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the metro area has grown by 0.98% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a growing pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -9.84%, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas are currently sitting on the market for a median of 58 days, with a year-over-year increase of 3.6%. This indicates a moderately competitive market that is becoming slightly less heated, which could make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors, combined with its growth trend, places Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This suggests a deep talent pool suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses.

In conclusion, Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas offers a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, moderate wage growth, and a relatively balanced unemployment rate, making it an attractive location for businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the decline in building permits, which could impact future affordability and workforce accommodation.

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
57.2th percentile
Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		74
Unemployment 20% weight		12
Wage Growth 15% weight		82
Cost of Living 12% weight		78
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		60
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		28
Days on Market 5% weight		64
Office Economy 3% weight		90

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.7% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +5.8% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.1% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.2% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -11.7% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 75 days median, -2.6% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 57.2th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 74th percentile, and its top-tier wage growth, at 82nd percentile with a 5.78% year-over-year increase. These metrics signal a city with genuine job market expansion and rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has seen employment growth of 1.11% year-over-year and a 0.294% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a sign of a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.15 further reinforces this, placing the city in the 74th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford stands at 4.70%, which ranks in the 12th percentile, indicating a relatively high level of unemployment compared to other metros. This suggests that the job market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire, but it also implies weaker local consumer demand. Businesses looking to staff up may find a more accessible labor pool here compared to tighter markets.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 5.78%, Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is experiencing fast wage growth, ranking it in the 82nd percentile. This rapid increase in wages signals rising labor costs for employers but also means workers have increasing purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local businesses relying on consumer spending.

Cost of Living

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a cost of living score that ranks it in the 78th percentile, with a PSF of \$223/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$33.52, resulting in a ratio of 6.65. The fact that PSF is falling by 2.6% year-over-year contributes to the city's affordability. This makes the city more attractive for talent without needing significant wage premiums, as the cost of living is relatively more affordable compared to its peers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is growing at a rate of 0.22% year-over-year, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. While this growth is positive, its slow pace may present a structural headwind for hiring, especially if businesses are

looking to rapidly expand their operations.

Building Permits

The city has seen a year-over-year decrease in building permits of 11.73%, ranking it in the 28th percentile. This decline suggests that the housing supply is not expanding as quickly as demand, potentially leading to a supply squeeze and future affordability issues for the workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford are currently sitting on the market for a median of 75 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.6%. This relatively fast market, ranking in the 64th percentile, means that homes are selling quickly, which can be challenging for relocating workers to find accommodation.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranked in the 90th percentile, Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in these sectors but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand and top-tier wage growth, making it an attractive location for companies looking to tap into a growing and skilled workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential future affordability and housing supply issues signaled by the decline in building permits, which could impact the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce.

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

B

AVERAGE

54.7th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		90
Unemployment 20% weight		70
Wage Growth 15% weight		8
Cost of Living 12% weight		2
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		48
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		98
Days on Market 5% weight		2
Office Economy 3% weight		70

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.1% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +0.5% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.3% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.5% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +120.2% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 36 days median, -10.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 54.7th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its top-tier labor demand and building permits. The city's economic character is defined by its strong employment growth of 1.34% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of +0.839% from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination of metrics suggests a city with a robust job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.34% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +0.839% from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area. This indicates that not only are more jobs being added, but existing workers are also working more hours, suggesting a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 7.01 places the city in the top tier, at the 90th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 4.10%, which places it at the 70th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring due to the limited availability of workers, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. The tight market implies that companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is +0.51%, which is in the bottom tier, ranking at the 8th percentile. This slow wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also indicates weak bargaining power for workers, potentially affecting their purchasing power. The stagnant wage growth may be a concern for businesses relying on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a cost of living score that places it in the bottom tier, at the 2nd percentile, with a PSF of \$811/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$53.77/hr, resulting in a ratio of 15.08. The fact that PSF is falling by -1.3% year-over-year is a key driver of affordability. However, the low percentile rank indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is growing at a rate of -0.48% year-over-year, which is near the median, ranking at the 48th percentile. This negative growth rate indicates that the labor force supply is contracting, presenting a structural

headwind for hiring and potentially limiting the city's ability to support rapid business expansion.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is +120.21%, placing the city in the top tier, at the 98th percentile. This significant increase in residential building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce in the future. The surge in permits is a positive sign for businesses concerned about the availability of housing for their employees.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 36 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -10.0%. This rapid market, ranking at the 2nd percentile, indicates that homes are selling very quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The fast-paced market could be a concern for businesses trying to attract talent from other areas.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara places it at the 70th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. The city's economy is well-suited for knowledge-intensive industries but may not be as conducive to industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, driven by top-tier employment growth and building permits. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively high cost of living, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially increasing labor costs.

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

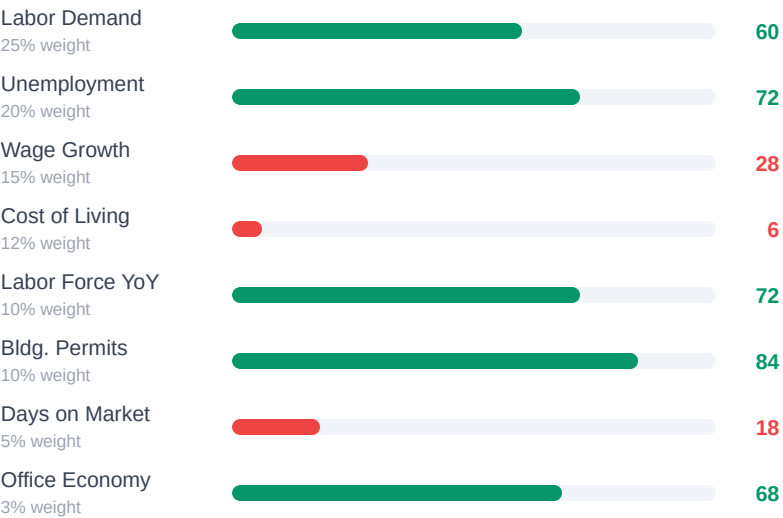
B

AVERAGE

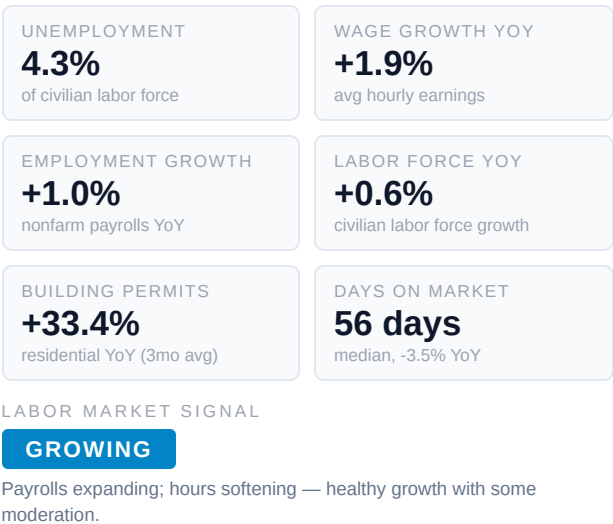
52.9th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 52.9th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and labor force growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.42, combining a 0.96% employment growth rate and a -0.228% weekly hours deviation, suggests genuine demand expansion. The unemployment rate of 4.30% and labor force growth rate of 0.60% also define the city's economic character.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.96% and weekly hours deviation of -0.228% indicate a moderate expansion of labor demand, signaling genuine demand growth as hours are not excessively above trend during job growth. This combination suggests that the city is adding jobs at a steady pace, with workers' hours not being overly stretched. The labor demand composite score of 5.42, ranking in the 60th percentile, reinforces this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.30% ranks in the 72nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may face moderate competition for talent, but it is still possible to hire without excessive wage pressure. The relatively low unemployment rate implies that workers have some bargaining power, but it is not extremely high.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 1.95% is below average, ranking in the 28th percentile, indicating stagnant to moderate wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is not increasing quickly either. The implication is a relatively flat cost environment for businesses, but with limited bargaining power for workers.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in New York Newark-Jersey City is relatively expensive, with a percentile rank of 6th, due to a PSF of \$490/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$40.39, resulting in a ratio of 12.13. Although the PSF is falling by 0.6% YoY, the city remains expensive, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The low affordability score means that businesses may need to compensate employees for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 0.60% year-over-year, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential employees, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations. The increasing labor force supply is a favorable condition for businesses looking to grow.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is 33.43%, ranking in the 84th percentile, indicating a significant expansion of housing supply. This rapid growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is high, and the future housing supply is likely to increase, improving affordability and accommodating a growing workforce. The rising permits signal a positive outlook for future affordability and workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 56 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 3.5%, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. The low percentile rank of 18th means that homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The fast-paced market implies that workers may face competition when searching for homes, potentially affecting their decision to relocate.

Office Economy

The city has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share of 3.08, ranking in the 68th percentile. This suggests that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require specialized knowledge-economy talent. The city's strong office economy makes it an attractive location for businesses that rely on professional and office workers.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers businesses a growing labor force, expanding housing supply, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for various industries. However, the city's high cost of living and relatively tight labor market are significant constraints that businesses should factor into their decision-making process, potentially requiring wage premiums to attract and retain talent.

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

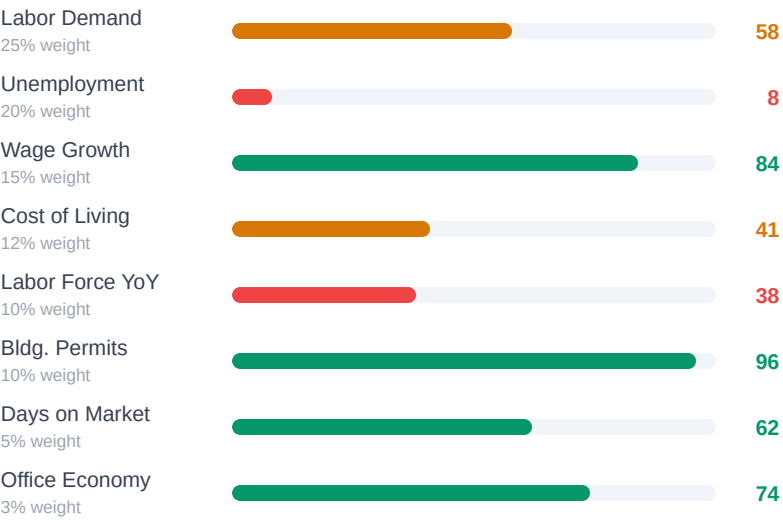
B

AVERAGE

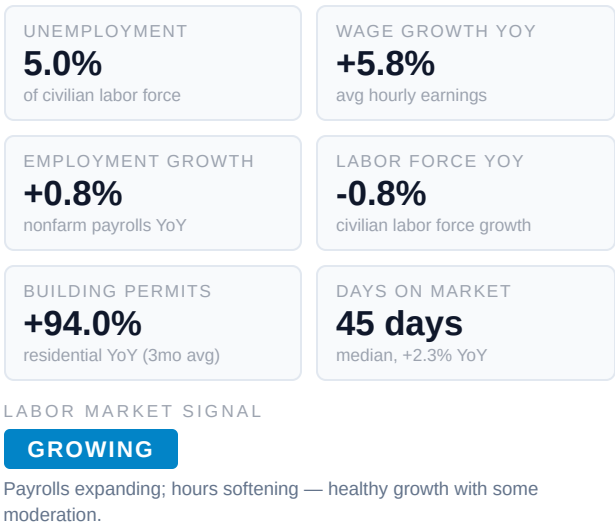
52.3th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking at the 52.3th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven significantly by its top-tier wage growth and strong building permits expansion. The city's economic character is most defined by its +5.79% year-over-year wage growth and a 93.96% increase in building permits, signaling a dynamic labor market and expanding housing supply. These metrics suggest a city with a strong economy but also potential labor cost pressures.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is +0.81% year-over-year, combined with a -0.048% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicating a near median labor demand composite score of 5.39. This combination signals a modest expansion in job numbers but with hours worked slightly below trend, suggesting some level of genuine demand but not at an accelerated pace. The labor market is growing, but the slight decrease in hours worked per week may indicate a degree of efficiency or caution among employers.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue stands at 5.00%, placing it in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, which means the labor market is relatively tight. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages as companies compete for a limited pool of available workers. The practical implication for a business trying to hire in this market is the need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of +5.79%, Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue experiences fast wage growth, ranking it in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This rapid wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, which can be a challenge for businesses but is beneficial for worker purchasing power, as employees see their earnings increase. The implication is a trade-off between higher labor costs for employers and increased consumer spending power in the local economy.

Cost of Living

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a cost of living score that places it near the median at the 41st percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$432/sqft to \$47.42/hr, equating to a ratio of 9.11. Given that the PSF is decreasing by -1.8% year-over-year, the city is becoming more affordable relative to wages. This affordability, although not the highest, means that the city can attract talent without necessarily requiring significant wage premiums, making it somewhat competitive in the labor market.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is shrinking at a rate of -0.77% year-over-year, indicating a contraction in the labor force supply. This negative growth rate suggests that the pool of available workers is decreasing, which can pose a structural headwind for hiring and may exacerbate the challenges of a tight labor market. Businesses looking to expand or relocate may find it challenging to find the necessary talent.

Building Permits

The city has seen a significant increase of 93.96% in residential building permits year-over-year, placing it in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This substantial growth in building permits signals that the housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth in the future. The rapid expansion in permits is a positive sign for future affordability and the ability to attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.3%. This increase, coupled with the absolute level, suggests a market that is slightly slowing down, becoming more accessible for relocating workers. However, with a percentile rank of 62, the market remains relatively competitive, though the slight increase in days on market may indicate a healthy normalization rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a deep professional talent pool, with an office and professional worker share composite score ranking it above average at the 74th percentile. This suggests the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that rely on a knowledgeable and specialized workforce. Conversely, it may be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area offers businesses a dynamic economy with strong wage growth and an expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market and potential for high labor costs due to rapid wage growth, which could impact operational expenses and require strategic hiring and retention practices.

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

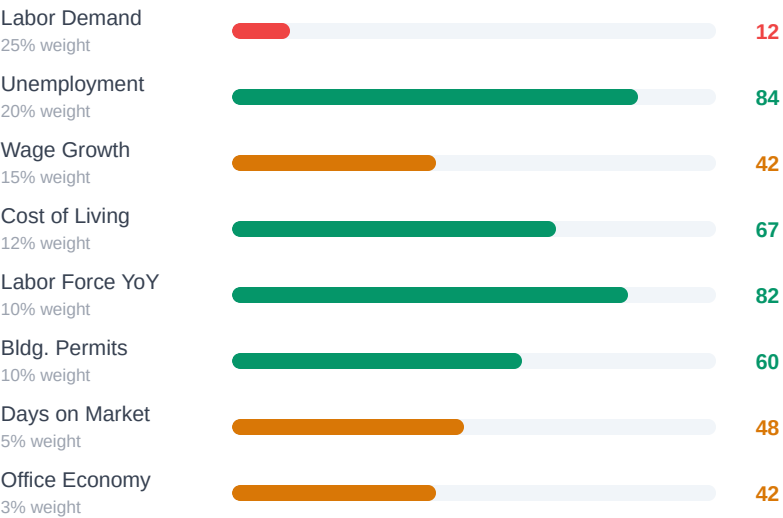
B

AVERAGE

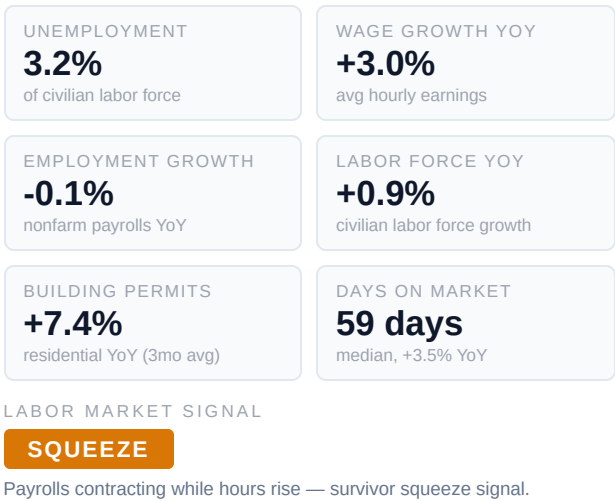
52.0th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 52.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low unemployment rate of 3.20% and a labor force growth rate of 0.88% YoY. The city's economic character is most defined by these two metrics, indicating a tight labor market with an expanding workforce. Specifically, the unemployment rate and labor force growth rate suggest a city with a strong job market and a growing pool of potential employees.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Atlanta is -0.11% YoY, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +0.454% from its own 12-month baseline, signaling a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This indicates that while there may not be significant job growth, existing workers are taking on more hours, suggesting some level of demand but not genuine expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.69 falls in the bottom tier, at the 12th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Atlanta is 3.20%, which ranks in the top tier at the 84th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face significant challenges in finding available workers, potentially leading to wage pressure. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have considerable bargaining power.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Atlanta is +2.99% YoY, which is near the median, ranking at the 42nd percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate, and worker purchasing power is increasing, though not dramatically. This balance could be beneficial for businesses looking to manage labor costs while still attracting and retaining talent.

Cost of Living

Atlanta has a cost of living score that ranks in the 67th percentile, with a PSF of \$195/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$37.03/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.27, which is above average. However, the PSF is falling by -0.5% YoY, which is a key driver of its relatively high affordability score. This means that Atlanta is more affordable than many of its peer cities, which could be a significant advantage for talent attraction without needing to offer wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Atlanta is growing at a rate of +0.88% YoY, which is in the top tier, ranking at the 82nd percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a growing pool of potential employees. This growth can help mitigate some of the challenges posed by the low unemployment rate.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Atlanta is increasing by +7.37% YoY, which ranks above average at the 60th percentile. This growth in residential building permits signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. This is a positive indicator for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Atlanta is 59 days, with a YoY increase of +3.5%, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile. This suggests a relatively balanced market that is not overly competitive, making it accessible for workers relocating to the city. The rising DOM indicates a healthy normalization of the market rather than a sign of demand erosion.

Office Economy

Atlanta's professional and office worker share composite score places it near the median, at the 42nd percentile. This indicates a moderately deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, though it may not be as strong as in other cities. Atlanta is well-suited for knowledge-economy businesses but may be less ideal for those requiring a large industrial or logistics workforce.

In conclusion, Atlanta offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market with an expanding workforce, moderate wage growth, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the low unemployment rate, which could lead to significant challenges in hiring and potentially drive up labor costs. Despite this, Atlanta's growing labor force and expanding housing supply are positive indicators for its future as a business location.

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

B

AVERAGE

51.3th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		22
Unemployment 20% weight		56
Wage Growth 15% weight		68
Cost of Living 12% weight		84
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		56
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		32
Days on Market 5% weight		94
Office Economy 3% weight		28

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 4.2%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +4.9%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.1%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth -0.0%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -10.3%	DAYS ON MARKET median, +12.8% YoY 44 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 51.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average wage growth and highly affordable cost of living, scoring 84th percentile. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, with wage growth at +4.94% YoY and a cost of living ratio of \$214/sqft to \$37.54/hr, indicating a relatively affordable environment. This affordability is further underscored by the cost of living's top-tier ranking.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -0.10% YoY, combined with a -0.673% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, suggesting that the labor market is not experiencing significant growth. The negative hours deviation alongside negative employment growth points to a weakening labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 4.20%, placing it near the median at the 56th percentile. This rate suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, it's not so high as to indicate a severely weak local consumer demand, offering a relatively balanced environment for hiring.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in the area is +4.94% YoY, which is above average, ranking at the 68th percentile. This fast wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also indicates strong worker purchasing power. Businesses should anticipate higher payroll expenses but also a workforce with increasing disposable income.

Cost of Living

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a cost of living score that ranks at the 84th percentile, indicating it is more affordable compared to its peers. With a PSF of \$214/sqft and hourly earnings of \$37.54, the ratio of 5.70, combined with a -3.2% YoY change in PSF, suggests that the city offers a talent attraction advantage without needing significant wage premiums. This affordability is a major draw for businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a YoY growth rate of -0.04%, indicating a slightly contracting labor pool. This negative growth suggests a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is not expanding. Businesses may face challenges in finding new talent in a shrinking labor pool.

Building Permits

The area has seen a -10.35% YoY change in residential building permits, signaling a tightening in housing supply. This decrease in permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with potential demand. This could lead to increased housing costs and reduced attractiveness for relocating workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 44 days, with a +12.8% YoY increase, placing it at the 94th percentile. This slower market means homes are sitting longer before being sold, indicating a more accessible and less competitive environment for workers relocating to the city. However, in the context of a weakening labor market, this could also signal demand erosion.

Office Economy

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has an office economy score that ranks at the 28th percentile, indicating a less deep professional talent pool compared to other metros. This suggests the city is less suited for businesses requiring a large pool of tech, finance, or consulting talent but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

The bottom line for businesses considering Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is that it offers a unique blend of affordability and above-average wage growth, making it an attractive location for talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint is the contracting labor demand and shrinking labor pool, which could pose significant challenges for hiring and workforce expansion.

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

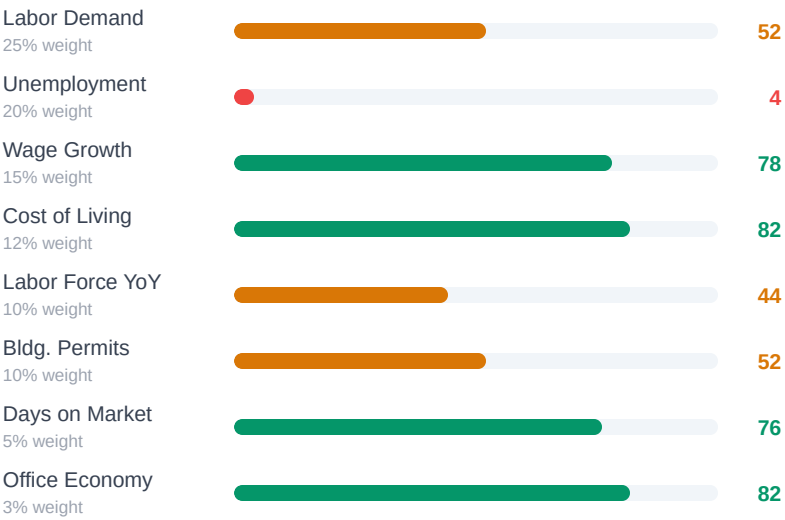
B

AVERAGE

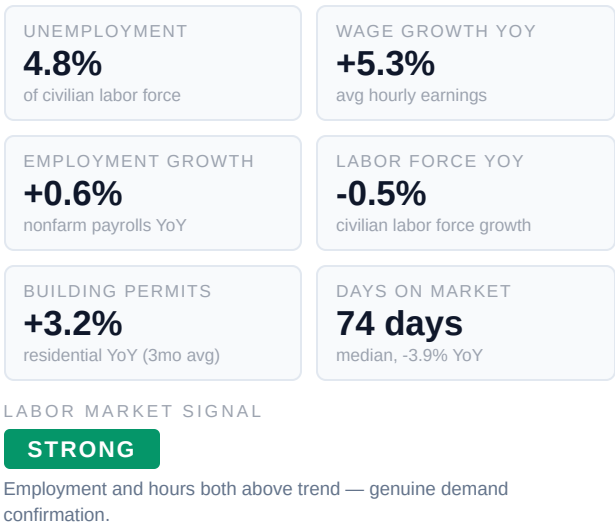
51.2th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 51.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average wage growth and highly affordable cost of living. The city's economic character is defined by a wage growth rate of 5.33% year-over-year and a cost of living ratio of \$233/sqft to \$37.12/hr, which is in the top tier of affordability at the 82nd percentile. This unique combination signals a city with strong labor market dynamics and attractive living costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 0.56% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +0.240% from its own trend, indicating a genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing a modest increase in jobs and hours worked, signaling a healthy labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.32 places the city near the median, indicating a balanced labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 4.80%, which is in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This low unemployment rate means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The tight market also suggests that workers have significant bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 5.33%, which is above average at the 78th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies that employer labor costs are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power. The strong wage growth is a double-edged sword, benefiting workers but potentially increasing costs for businesses.

Cost of Living

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a cost of living ratio of \$233/sqft to \$37.12/hr, with the price per square foot falling by 5.7% year-over-year, making it highly affordable at the 82nd percentile. This affordability is a significant talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring large wage premiums. The falling PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this high affordability score.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is shrinking at a rate of -0.50% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This decline in labor force growth poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of available workers is decreasing.

Businesses may need to adapt their hiring strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in training and development programs.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is increasing by 3.19% year-over-year, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This growth in building permits suggests that developer confidence is rising, and future housing supply is likely to improve, which should help maintain affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 74 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 3.9%, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. This fast market means that relocating workers may face competition for housing, and businesses may need to offer relocation assistance or flexible housing options to attract talent.

Office Economy

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a deep professional talent pool, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, making it well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. The city's strong office economy is a significant advantage for businesses requiring specialized knowledge workers, but it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, affordable living costs, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for businesses in the knowledge economy. However, the city's tight labor market and declining labor force growth pose significant risks and constraints that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating this location for their business operations.

Columbus

Columbus

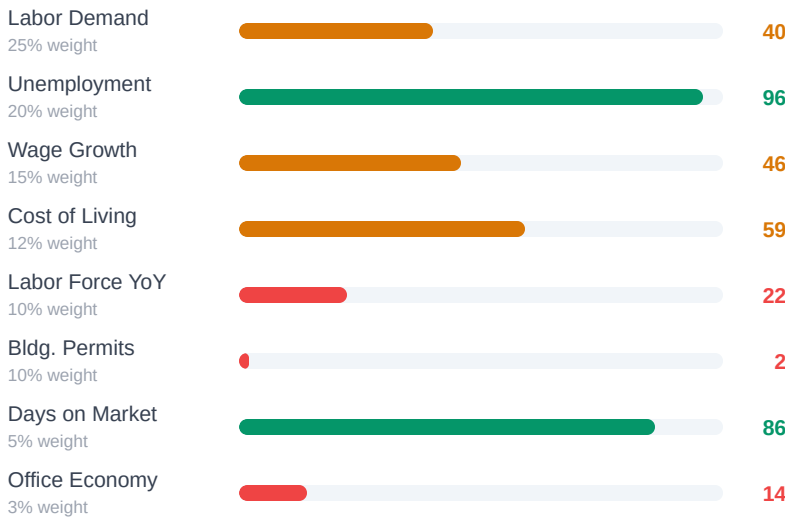
B

AVERAGE

50.3th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.2%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.3%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.0%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.4%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-37.5%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

44 days

median, +7.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus, with an overall grade of B and a composite score ranking it at the 50.3th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its low unemployment rate of 3.20% and a near-median labor demand composite score of 4.57. The city's economic character is most defined by its tight labor market and moderate labor demand growth, with employment growth at +0.02% year-over-year and weekly hours deviating +0.246% from its own trend. These metrics suggest a city with a strong job market but potential challenges in hiring due to low unemployment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.02% and hours deviation of +0.246% indicate a genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in labor demand, driven by the addition of new jobs and existing workers taking on more hours. The labor demand composite score of 4.57, ranking at the 40th percentile, further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.20% ranks at the 96th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in Columbus may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. With such a low unemployment rate, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +3.31% ranks at the 46th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power. The moderate wage growth may help balance the tight labor market, as workers may be more willing to switch jobs or consider new opportunities with competitive pay.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 59th, Columbus is relatively affordable compared to its peers, particularly given its PSF of \$205/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$34.40/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.96. The fact that PSF is falling by -0.5% year-over-year further enhances the city's affordability. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as workers may not require wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -1.35% year-over-year, ranking at the 22nd percentile. This decline in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in workforce development programs to address the shrinking labor pool.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -37.46%, ranking at the 2nd percentile, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply expansion. This tightening of the housing market may lead to future affordability challenges and could impact the city's ability to attract and accommodate a growing workforce. The lack of new housing supply could exacerbate the existing tight labor market conditions.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.3%, ranking at the 86th percentile. This slower market means that homes are sitting longer before being sold, which could be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as they may have more time to find a suitable home. However, this trend also indicates a potential normalization of the housing market, which could impact future affordability and workforce attraction.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share composite score ranking at the 14th percentile, Columbus has a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city may be less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, the city may still be attractive to businesses with more diverse or industrial workforce needs.

In conclusion, Columbus offers a business a tight labor market with moderate labor demand growth, a relatively affordable cost of living, and a slowing housing market. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the shrinking labor force supply, which poses a significant challenge for hiring and workforce expansion. This constraint may require businesses to adapt their recruitment strategies or consider investments in workforce development to thrive in the Columbus market.

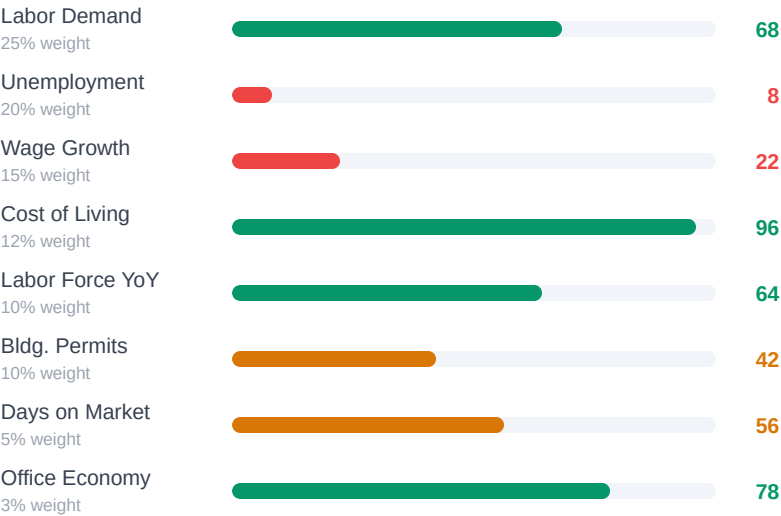
Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

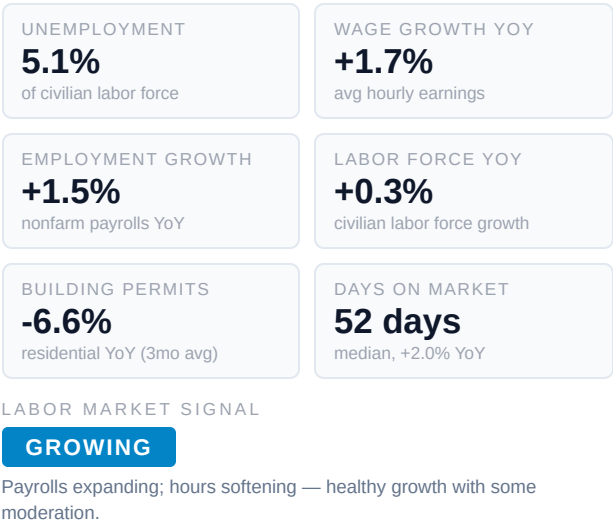
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.2th percentile
Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 49.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high cost of living affordability, with a percentile rank of 96th, and its below-average wage growth rate of 1.71% year-over-year. The labor demand composite score of 5.71, ranking at the 68th percentile, also plays a significant role in shaping the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 1.46% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of -0.639% from its own trend. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs and hours are running above trend. The labor demand composite score of 5.71, ranking at the 68th percentile, further supports this indication of a growing labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 5.10%, ranking at the 8th percentile, indicating a relatively high level of unemployment. This means the market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses reliant on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 1.71%, ranking at the 22nd percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also translates to weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has a cost of living percentile rank of 96th, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$169/sqft to \$36.90/hr, or 4.58. This high rank indicates that the city is more affordable relative to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by 2.3% year-over-year further enhances the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is growing at a rate of 0.28% year-over-year, ranking at the 64th percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a favorable condition for businesses looking to hire. However, the growth rate is relatively modest, suggesting that hiring capacity, while present, is not rapidly increasing.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is -6.61%, ranking near the median at the 42nd percentile. This decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.0%. This indicates a relatively stable market that is not overly competitive, making it accessible for workers relocating to the city. The near-median percentile rank of 56th further supports this assessment, suggesting a balanced market.

Office Economy

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has an office economy percentile rank of 78th, indicating a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions that require specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area offers businesses a unique combination of affordability and access to a professional talent pool, but the single biggest risk or constraint is the stagnant wage growth, which could limit worker purchasing power and bargaining ability. Despite this, the city's overall economic landscape, particularly its high affordability and expanding labor force, presents opportunities for businesses looking to establish or expand operations in a relatively accessible market.

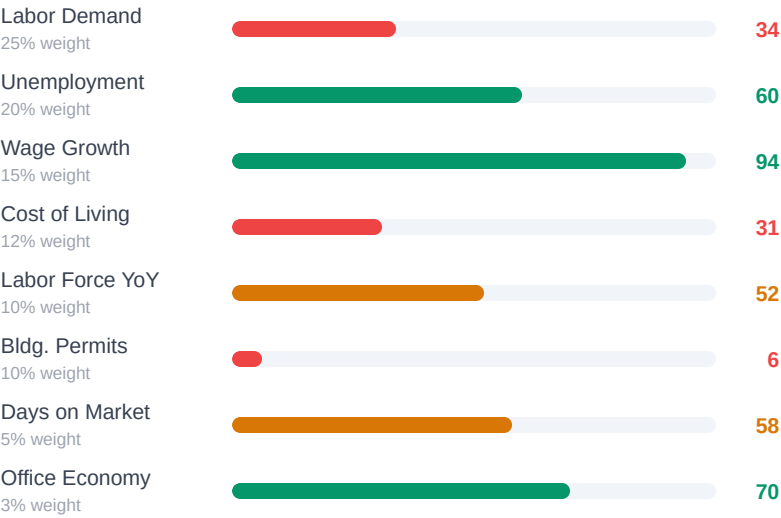
Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

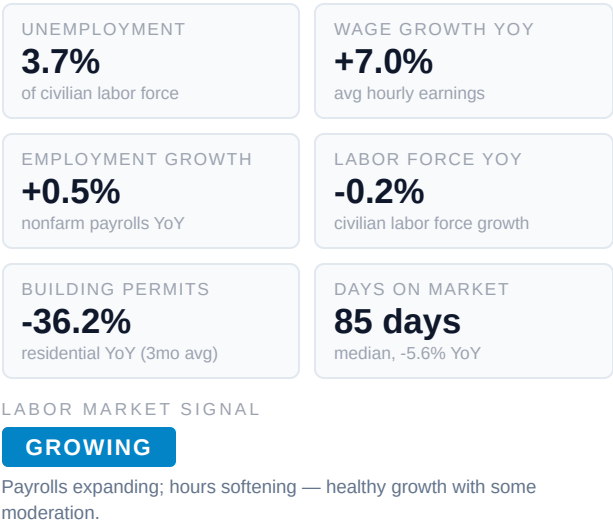
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.1th percentile
Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 49.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 7.02%, and its struggling labor demand, with a composite score of 4.52, ranking below average at the 34th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 0.48% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.452% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, as the hours worked are below trend despite some job growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.52, ranking at the 34th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 3.70%, ranking at the 60th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. With a tight market, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 7.02%, ranking at the 94th percentile, indicating fast and strong wage growth. This implies that employer labor costs are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. As a result, businesses may face higher labor costs, but the local workforce will have more disposable income to spend.

Cost of Living

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a cost of living score ranking at the 31st percentile, with a PSF of \$355/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$34.68/hr, resulting in a ratio of 10.24. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The PSF has decreased by 0.8% year-over-year, but the city's affordability score remains below average. This means that attracting talent without offering wage premiums may be challenging due to the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is growing at a rate of -0.22% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is contracting, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring in the city. Businesses may need to consider this constraint when planning their workforce expansion.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has decreased by 36.23% year-over-year, ranking at the 6th percentile. This sharp decline signals a tightening of the housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This could be a significant risk for businesses relying on a mobile workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 85 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 5.6%. This indicates a relatively fast-moving market, ranking at the 58th percentile. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market may be competitive, making it essential for businesses to consider relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

Office Economy

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has an office economy score ranking at the 70th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers indicating a deep talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but may be less suitable for industries with primarily industrial or logistics-based workforces.

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the city's high cost of living, tightening housing supply, and contracting labor force pose significant risks and constraints that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating this location for their business operations.

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

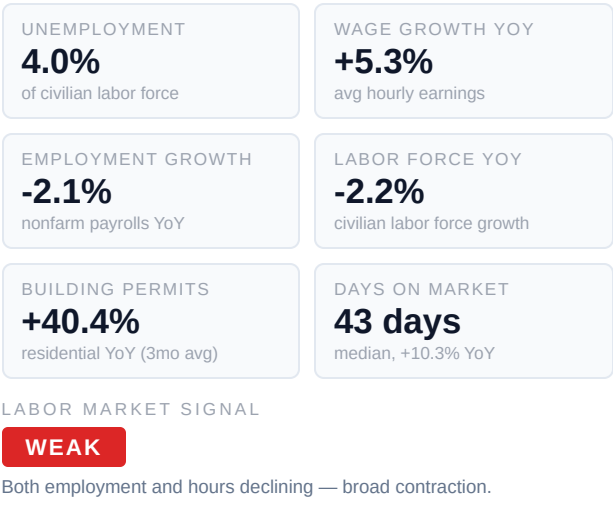
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.5th percentile
Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 47.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its above-average wage growth of 5.31% year-over-year. The combination of a 4.00% unemployment rate and strong wage growth suggests a complex labor market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is -2.15% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.969% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. This suggests a lack of genuine demand expansion in the labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 4.00%, which ranks at the 60th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also implies upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 5.31%, which is above average and ranks at the 76th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, while workers may enjoy improved living standards.

Cost of Living

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has a cost of living score that ranks at the 76th percentile, with a PSF of \$298/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$45.17/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.60. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, with a PSF that is falling by 2.3% year-over-year. This affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is contracting at a rate of -2.20% year-over-year, which ranks at the 6th percentile. This decline in labor force supply implies that the city may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to adapt their hiring strategies to accommodate this declining labor force.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is increasing by 40.37% year-over-year, which ranks at the 90th percentile. This rapid expansion in housing supply suggests that the city is experiencing a surge in developer confidence, which may lead to improved affordability and accommodation options for the workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.3%, which ranks at the 90th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, this may also signal a normalization of the market after a period of rapid growth.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria ranks at the 32nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool compared to other cities. This suggests that the city may be less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies, but may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles.

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area offers a unique combination of above-average wage growth and relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for businesses that can adapt to its tight labor market and declining labor force supply. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the low labor demand, which may limit the availability of skilled workers and require creative hiring strategies to overcome.

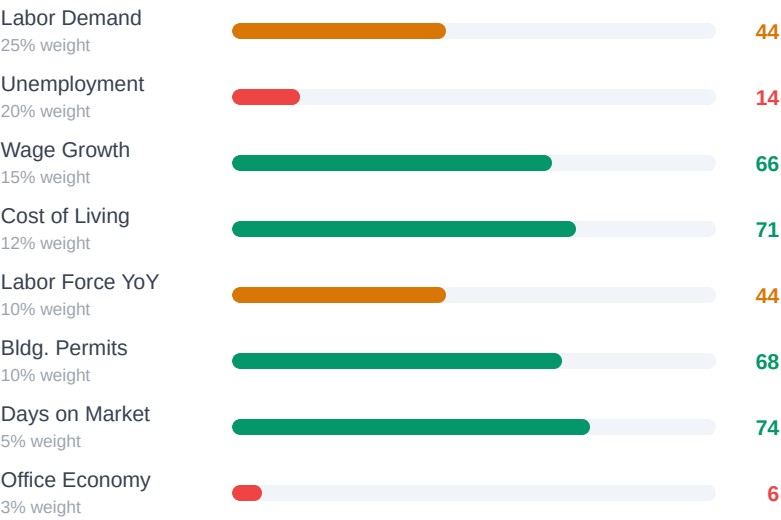
Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

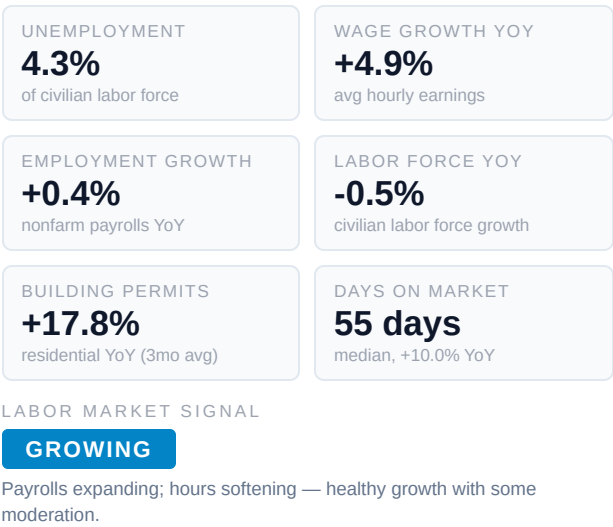
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.4th percentile
Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 47.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 4.86% year-over-year and its relatively low unemployment rate of 4.30%, which suggests a tight labor market. These metrics indicate a city with rising labor costs and potential challenges in hiring.

Labor Demand

Oklahoma City's employment growth rate is 0.43% year-over-year, and its weekly hours deviation from trend is -0.070%, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.83, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This combination signals a modest expansion of jobs, but with hours worked slightly below trend, it may indicate some level of survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand is not strongly indicative of genuine demand expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Oklahoma City is 4.30%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, which means the labor market is relatively tight. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring due to the scarcity of available workers, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. The low unemployment rate suggests that the city's workforce is largely employed, making it harder for companies to find and recruit new talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Oklahoma City is 4.86%, placing it above average at the 66th percentile. This rate of wage growth is relatively fast, suggesting that labor costs for employers are rising. For workers, this means increased purchasing power, which can be beneficial for the local economy. However, for businesses, it implies a need to budget for higher labor costs.

Cost of Living

Oklahoma City has a cost of living score that ranks it above average at the 71st percentile, with a price per square foot of \$171 and average hourly earnings of \$33.54, resulting in a ratio of 5.10. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The affordability of Oklahoma City gives it a talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a good standard of living without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Oklahoma City is growing at a rate of -0.50% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This negative growth rate indicates that the labor force supply is contracting, which could pose a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. A shrinking labor pool limits the potential for companies to find new employees, making growth more challenging.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Oklahoma City has increased by 17.78% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 68th percentile. This significant increase in residential building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The rise in building permits is a positive signal for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Oklahoma City is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.0%, ranking above average at the 74th percentile. This longer days on market indicates a slower, more buyer-friendly market. For workers relocating to Oklahoma City, this means a more accessible and less competitive housing market, potentially making relocation easier.

Office Economy

Oklahoma City's share of professional and office workers is 0.60, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This suggests a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors, making the city less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce requirements, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Oklahoma City offers a relatively affordable cost of living and a growing housing supply, which are attractive for talent retention and business expansion. However, the city's tight labor market and rising wage growth pose significant challenges for businesses looking to hire and expand, making labor costs and recruitment strategies critical considerations for any company deciding to locate or grow operations in Oklahoma City.

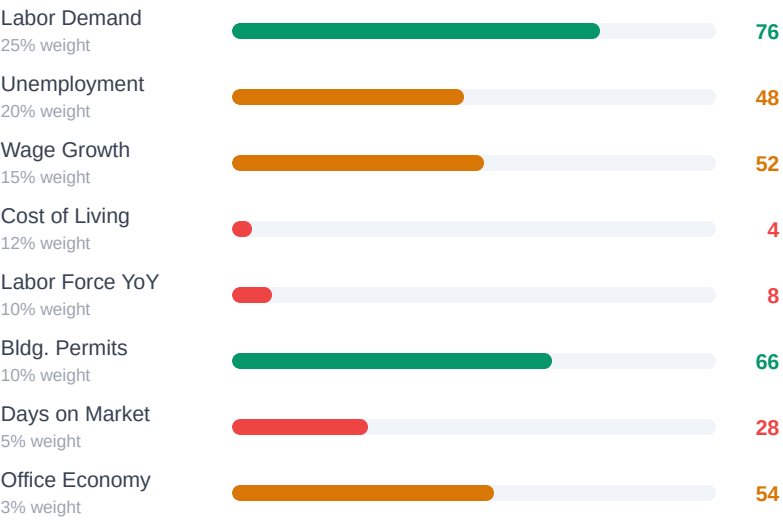
Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

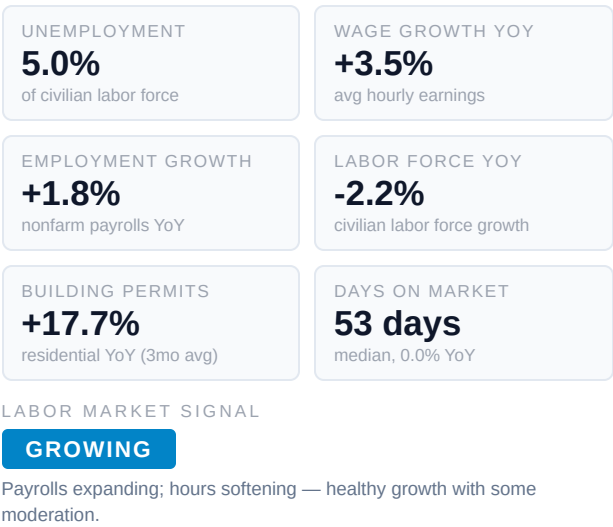
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.3th percentile
Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 47.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score of 6.18 ranking it in the 76th percentile, and its cost of living, which is in the bottom tier with a 4th percentile rank due to a high PSF to wages ratio of \$652/sqft to \$41.61/hr. The labor demand and cost of living metrics provide a mixed picture of the city's economic health.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 1.83% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.681% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as jobs are being added and hours are running above trend, indicating a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.18 reinforces this signal, ranking the city in the 76th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 5.00%, ranking it in the 48th percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This suggests that the market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter labor markets. However, this also implies that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the availability of labor.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 3.48%, ranking it in the 52nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a pace that is not excessively high. Meanwhile, workers in the area are experiencing an increase in purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses through increased consumer spending.

Cost of Living

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim has a cost of living score ranking it in the 4th percentile, indicating that it is one of the more expensive cities relative to peers, with a PSF to wages ratio of \$652/sqft to \$41.61/hr. However, the PSF is falling by 2.1% year-over-year, which is a key driver of affordability. Despite this, the city's high cost of living means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the city's affordability is a significant disadvantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is contracting at a rate of -2.18% year-over-year, ranking it in the 8th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, presenting a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion in the

area. Businesses looking to grow their workforce may face challenges due to the declining labor pool.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is increasing by 17.69% year-over-year, ranking it in the 66th percentile. This signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth in the future. The increase in building permits is a positive indicator for businesses considering relocation or expansion, as it suggests that the city is investing in its housing infrastructure.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 53 days, with a year-over-year change of 0.0%, ranking it in the 28th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The low percentile rank suggests that the market is competitive, and businesses may need to provide relocation assistance to help employees navigate the housing market.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim ranks in the 54th percentile, indicating a near-median depth of professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for a variety of businesses, including those in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but may not have a significant advantage in these areas. The city's office economy is neither particularly strong nor weak, making it a viable option for businesses that do not require a highly specialized workforce.

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area offers businesses a mixed economic environment, with strong labor demand and moderate wage growth, but also a high cost of living and a shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially offsetting the benefits of the city's strong labor market.

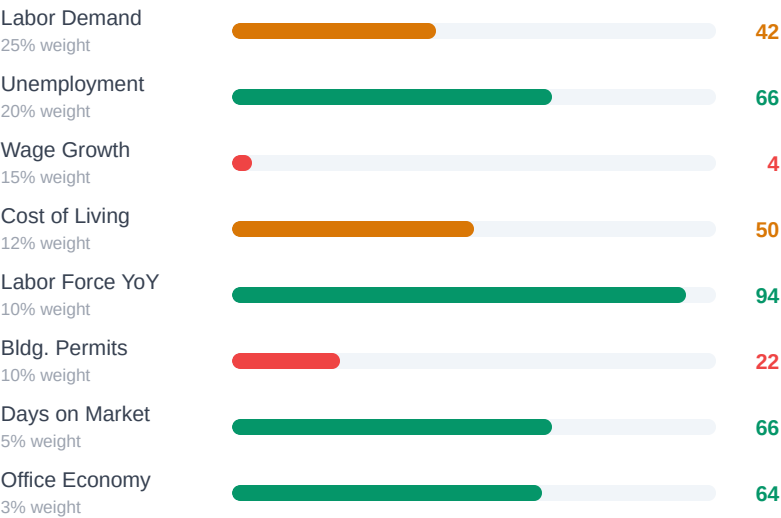
Cleveland

Cleveland

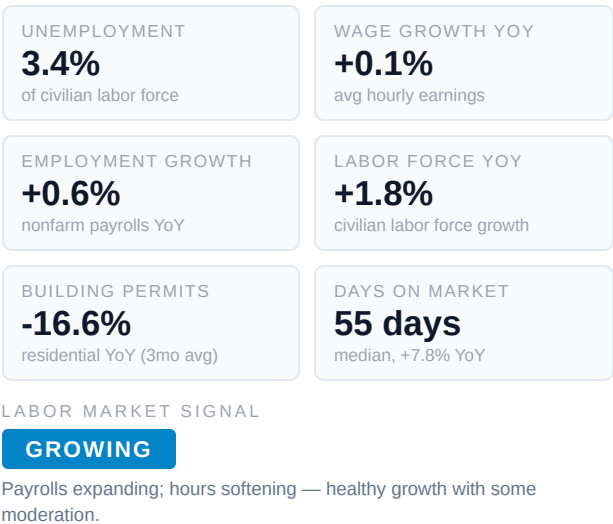
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.1th percentile
Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland earns an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 47.1th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its near-median labor demand composite score of 4.66 and its bottom-tier wage growth of +0.10% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment, with labor demand neither strongly expanding nor contracting, but with notable pressure on wage costs.

Labor Demand

Cleveland's employment growth rate is +0.57% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.438% below the city's own trend. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are not running above trend during a period of modest job growth. The labor market is not experiencing significant contraction, but the below-trend hours suggest some level of inefficiency or underutilization.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cleveland is 3.40%, ranking it in the 66th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with more wage pressure likely. However, the current rate does not suggest an overly competitive market that would significantly hinder recruitment efforts.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cleveland is +0.10% year-over-year, placing it in the bottom tier of the 4th percentile. This stagnant wage growth environment means labor costs for employers are not rising significantly, but it also indicates weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. This could affect the attractiveness of the city for talent seeking better compensation.

Cost of Living

Cleveland's cost of living, with a PSF of \$143/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$34.00/hr, results in a ratio of 4.21, ranking it near the median in the 50th percentile. This suggests the city is neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. The 13.5% year-over-year increase in PSF, however, indicates rising costs. This mixed affordability picture means that while Cleveland may not require significant wage premiums to attract talent, it does not offer a substantial cost-of-living advantage either.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cleveland is growing at a rate of +1.80% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier of the 94th percentile. This indicates an expanding workforce supply, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -16.61%, ranking Cleveland below average in the 22nd percentile. This decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Cleveland are currently sitting on the market for a median of 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.8%. This places the city above average in terms of days on market, indicating a slower, more buyer-friendly market. For workers relocating to Cleveland, this could mean a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

Cleveland's share of professional and office workers is 2.92, ranking it above average in the 64th percentile. This suggests a deep talent pool suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations. The city is less suited for industries requiring large industrial or logistics workforces.

In conclusion, Cleveland offers businesses a mixed economic environment with a tight labor market and stagnant wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for future affordability issues due to tightening housing supply, which could impact workforce attraction and accommodation. Despite this, the city's expanding labor force and deep professional talent pool are significant advantages for certain types of businesses.

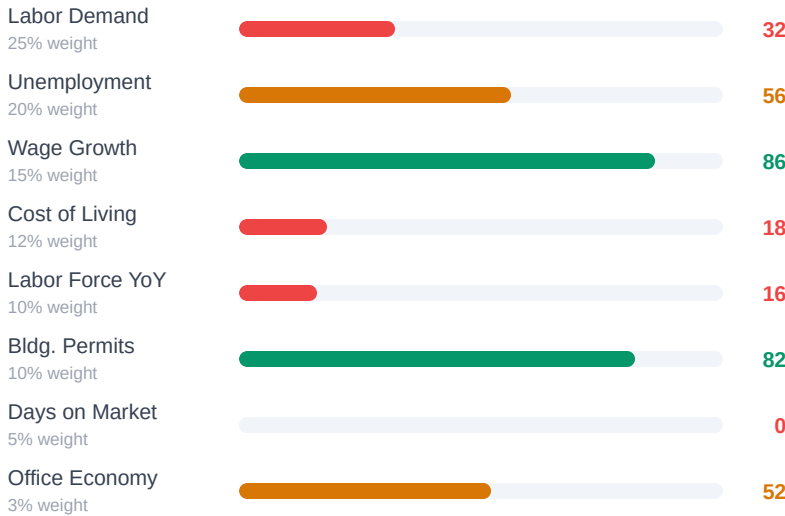
San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.7th percentile
Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.4%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+6.0%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.2%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-1.7%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+32.1%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
38 days
median, -15.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 45.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.99%, and its low labor force growth, with a year-over-year decline of -1.71%. These metrics signal a complex labor market with rising costs and tightening supply.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is +0.22% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.149% below trend. This combination signals a labor demand environment that is not strongly expanding, as the slight job growth is accompanied by hours that are below the city's own trend, indicating some level of survivor squeeze where remaining workers may be absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 4.40%, ranking near the median at the 56th percentile. This rate indicates a labor market that is neither extremely tight nor has significant slack, suggesting that businesses may face moderate challenges in hiring but without extreme wage pressure.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of +5.99%, San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont experiences fast wage growth, ranking it in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also indicates strong worker purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a cost of living score that places it in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$619/sqft to \$49.82/hr, equating to 12.42. Although the PSF is falling by -3.9% year-over-year, the city remains expensive relative to peers. This expense suggests that attracting talent without offering wage premiums could be challenging.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is declining by -1.71% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor supply. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the shrinking labor pool limits the availability of workers for businesses.

Building Permits

The city has seen a +32.14% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, signaling an expansion in future housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is high, which could lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future.

Days on Market

Homes in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont currently sit on the market for 38 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -15.6%. This fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market for relocating workers, making it potentially tough for them to find and secure housing.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile, San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a moderately deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city suited for businesses that require a knowledge-economy workforce, such as tech, finance, or consulting, but less ideal for industries with different labor needs.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and a moderately skilled workforce, but the single biggest risk or constraint is the city's expensive cost of living and contracting labor force, which can make talent attraction and retention challenging without significant wage premiums. Despite these challenges, the city's expanding housing supply, signaled by the increase in building permits, could mitigate some of these issues in the future. Overall, businesses must carefully weigh these factors when considering San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont as a location.

Birmingham

Birmingham

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.4th percentile
Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		54
Unemployment 20% weight		48
Wage Growth 15% weight		10
Cost of Living 12% weight		49
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		26
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		86
Days on Market 5% weight		46
Office Economy 3% weight		46

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.5% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +0.6% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.7% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.1% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +39.5% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 59 days median, +1.7% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it 45.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, is characterized by its near-median labor demand and cost of living, but notably weak wage growth at +0.57% year-over-year. The city's economic character is most defined by its sluggish wage growth and declining labor force, which contracted by -1.10% year-over-year. These metrics suggest that while Birmingham has some positive trends, it also faces challenges in terms of labor market vitality.

Labor Demand

Birmingham's employment growth rate of +0.65% year-over-year, combined with a +0.140% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit a modest one. This combination indicates that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in slightly more hours than usual, suggesting a degree of labor market tightening. However, the near-median composite score of 5.35 suggests that this demand is not exceptionally strong.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate of 3.50% is near the median, indicating a labor market with some slack but not excessive weakness. This rate suggests that businesses may face moderate competition for talent, but it is not an extremely tight market. As a result, hiring may be manageable, but wage pressure is not extreme.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of +0.57%, Birmingham's labor market is experiencing stagnant wage growth, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This slow wage growth implies that labor costs for employers are not rising quickly, but it also means that workers have limited bargaining power and purchasing power is not increasing rapidly.

Cost of Living

Birmingham's cost of living, with a PSF of \$159/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$32.79, resulting in a ratio of 4.85, is near the median in terms of affordability, ranking at the 49th percentile. This suggests that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be an advantage for attracting talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Birmingham is contracting at a rate of -1.10% year-over-year, indicating that the supply of workers is shrinking. This contraction implies that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring and expanding their workforce, as the pool of available workers is decreasing.

Building Permits

The city saw a +39.50% year-over-year increase in building permits, which is a top-tier performance, ranking at the 86th percentile. This surge in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce in the future.

Days on Market

Homes in Birmingham are currently sitting on the market for a median of 59 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.7%. This indicates a moderate pace of home sales, neither extremely fast nor slow. For workers relocating to the city, this suggests a relatively accessible housing market, but not one that is overly competitive.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranking at the 46th percentile, Birmingham has a moderately deep talent pool in these sectors. This makes the city suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and office skills, but it may not be the best fit for companies requiring extremely specialized or abundant tech, finance, or consulting talent.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers a relatively affordable cost of living and an expanding housing supply, which could attract businesses looking for a cost-effective location. However, the city's slow wage growth and contracting labor force are significant risks that decision-makers should consider, as they may limit the city's ability to support long-term business expansion and talent attraction.

Providence

Providence-Warwick

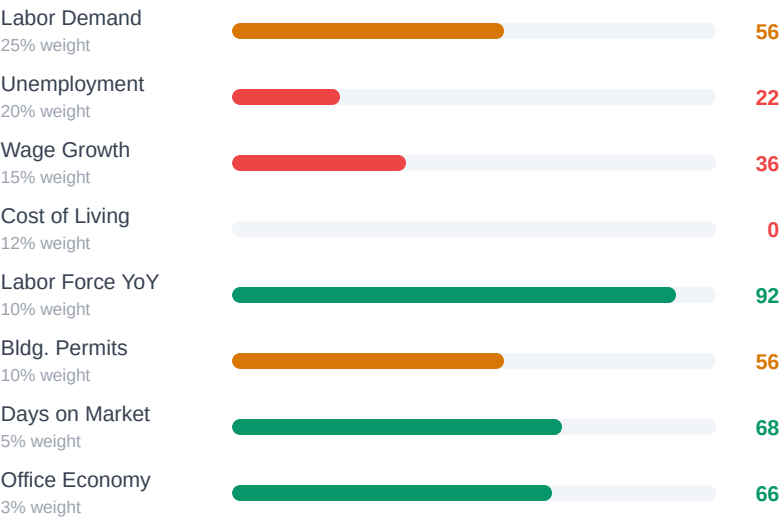
C+

POOR

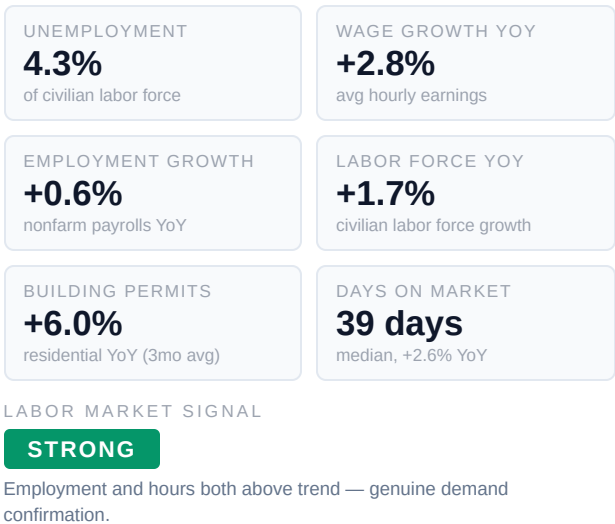
44.0th percentile

Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 44th out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high labor force growth rate of 1.69% YoY and its extremely low affordability, with a cost of living ratio of \$362/sqft to \$36.34/hr, ranking it at the 0th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a growing workforce but significant challenges in attracting and retaining talent due to high costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Providence-Warwick is 0.60% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating 0.226% above the city's own trend. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours are increasing, indicating a growing economy. However, the labor demand composite score of 5.37 ranks only at the 56th percentile, suggesting a moderate level of demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Providence-Warwick is 4.30%, ranking it at the 22nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The tight market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Providence-Warwick is 2.76%, ranking it at the 36th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. Workers in the area will see some increase in their purchasing power, but it may not be as strong as in other metros.

Cost of Living

Providence-Warwick has a cost of living ratio of \$362/sqft to \$36.34/hr, with the PSF increasing 9.4% YoY, ranking it at the 0th percentile for affordability. This means that the city is extremely expensive relative to peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering significant wage premiums. The high cost of living may deter some businesses from locating in the area.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Providence-Warwick is growing at a rate of 1.69% YoY, ranking it at the 92nd percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce. This suggests that the supply of workers is increasing, making it easier for businesses to hire and find talent. The growing labor force is a significant advantage for businesses looking to locate in the area.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Providence-Warwick is increasing by 5.95% YoY, ranking it at the 56th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may help improve affordability and accommodate the growing workforce. However, the moderate pace of growth may not be enough to keep up with demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Providence-Warwick is 39 days, with a 2.6% YoY increase, ranking it at the 68th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is relatively accessible for workers relocating to the area, with homes taking a moderate amount of time to sell. The increasing days on market may indicate a normalization of the market.

Office Economy

Providence-Warwick has an office economy percentile rank of 66, indicating a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, it may be less suitable for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Providence-Warwick metro area offers businesses a growing workforce and a deep talent pool in professional sectors, but the extremely high cost of living is a significant constraint. The single biggest risk for decision-makers is the challenge of attracting and retaining talent without offering substantial wage premiums, which may offset the benefits of locating in the area.

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

C+

POOR

43.7th percentile

Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		14
25% weight		
Unemployment		32
20% weight		
Wage Growth		40
15% weight		
Cost of Living		20
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		98
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		94
10% weight		
Days on Market		88
5% weight		
Office Economy		58
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.9% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +2.9% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.3% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +2.9% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +87.2% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 51 days median, +13.3% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 43.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor force growth of +2.87% YoY and its high building permits growth of +87.24% YoY, indicating a expanding workforce and housing supply. However, its labor demand composite score of 3.73 ranks in the bottom tier, suggesting a mismatch between job growth and hours worked.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.27% YoY is modest, while the weekly hours deviation from trend is -0.951%, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. This metric ranks in the bottom tier, at the 14th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.90% is below average, ranking at the 32nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with more wage pressure. However, it also suggests a skilled and experienced workforce.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +2.89% is near median, ranking at the 40th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing worker purchasing power. While not extremely high, wage growth is still a factor to consider for businesses.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is relatively expensive, with a percentile rank of 20th, indicating a lower affordability score. The PSF to earnings ratio is \$458/sqft vs \$45.37/hr, resulting in a ratio of 10.09. This means that talent attraction may require wage premiums to compensate for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +2.87% YoY, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This top-tier growth rate, ranking at the 98th percentile, suggests a positive hiring capacity and a growing pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is +87.24%, indicating a significant expansion in housing supply. This top-tier growth rate, ranking at the 94th percentile, signals improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of +13.3%, ranking at the 88th percentile. This suggests a slower market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this also indicates a potential normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share is 2.84, ranking at the 58th percentile, indicating a deep but not exceptional talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but may not be the best fit for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a growing workforce and expanding housing supply, but also poses challenges in terms of labor demand and cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for wage pressure and talent attraction challenges due to the high cost of living, which may require careful consideration of compensation packages and relocation incentives.

Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

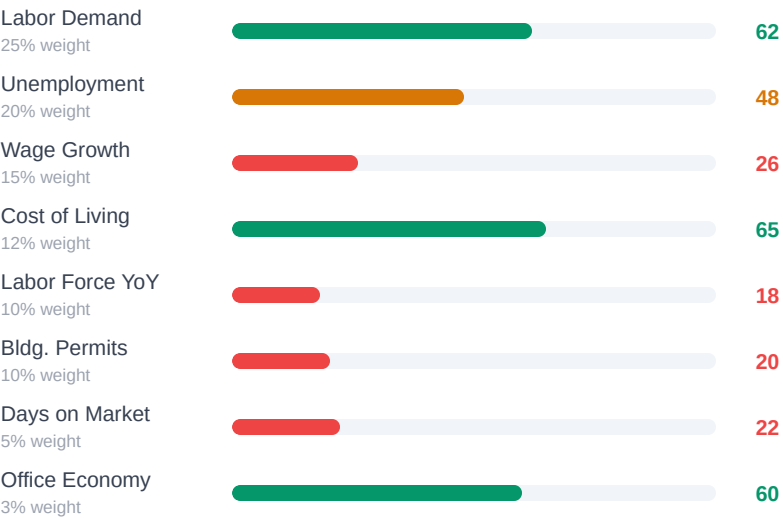
C+

POOR

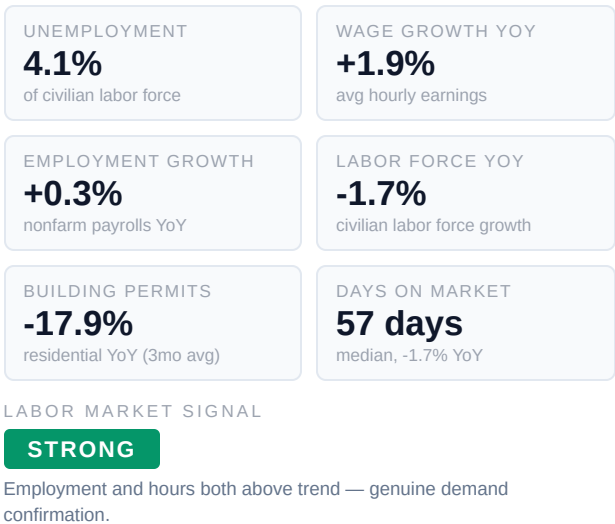
43.5th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 43.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score of 5.42 ranking it in the 62nd percentile, and its below-average wage growth of 1.94% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a city with a growing job market but relatively stagnant wages.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 0.31% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of 0.687% above its own trend, signaling genuine demand expansion. This indicates that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a strong labor market. The combination of these metrics points to a city with a growing economy and increasing labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 4.10%, ranking it near the median at the 48th percentile. This suggests a relatively balanced labor market with some slack, making it neither extremely tight nor overly loose. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate implies a manageable hiring process without excessive wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 1.94%, which is below average, ranking it in the 26th percentile. This slow wage growth suggests a relatively flat cost environment for employers but weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, businesses may benefit from lower labor costs, but workers may have limited purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a cost of living score ranking it in the 65th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$280/sqft to \$42.59/hr, or 6.57. The fact that the PSF is falling by 3.5% year-over-year makes the city more affordable relative to peers. This affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to hire.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is shrinking at a rate of -1.67% year-over-year, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding qualified candidates due to the shrinking labor force.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Denver-Aurora-Centennial has decreased by 17.89% year-over-year, ranking it below average at the 20th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. This could pose a risk to workforce accommodation and attraction.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 57 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 1.7%. This relatively fast market, ranking in the 22nd percentile, may make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. The competitive housing market could be a drawback for businesses trying to attract talent from other areas.

Office Economy

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking it in the 60th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that require a knowledgeable and specialized workforce. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented economies.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers a growing job market with above-average labor demand, but its slow wage growth and shrinking labor force supply pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for a business decision-maker is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing, ultimately affecting workforce accommodation and attraction.

Fresno

Fresno

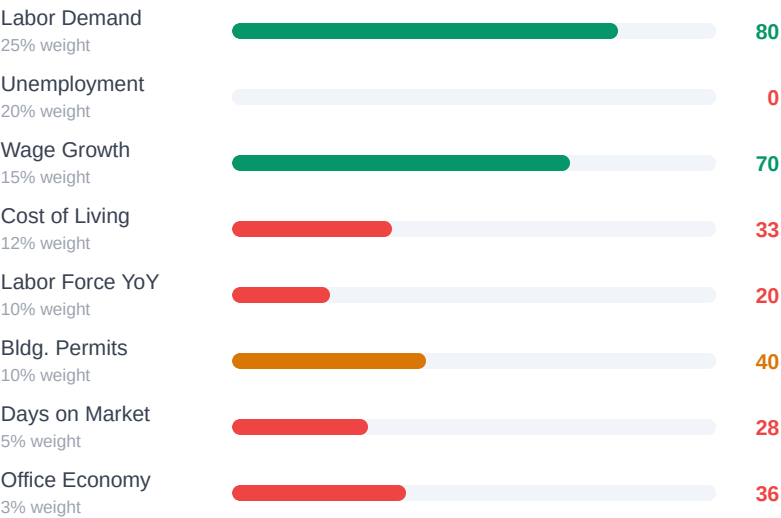
C+

POOR

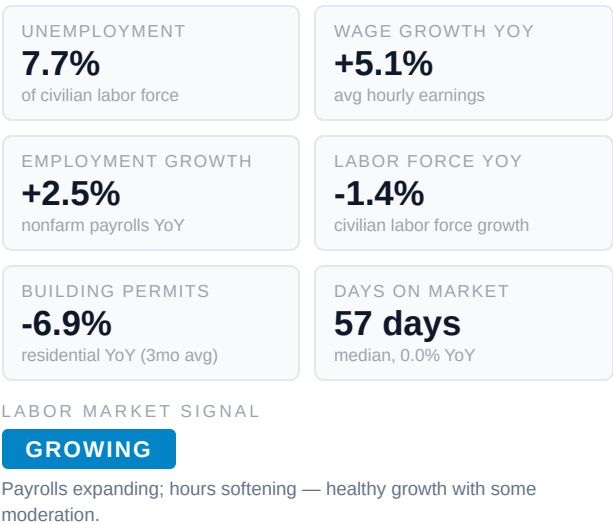
42.9th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Fresno has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it at the 42.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 80th percentile, and its high unemployment rate, which is in the bottom tier at the 0th percentile, standing at 7.70%. These two metrics signal a complex labor market with both opportunities and challenges.

Labor Demand

Fresno's employment growth rate is 2.47% year-over-year, and its weekly hours are -1.481% below its own trend, indicating a genuine demand expansion despite some inefficiencies in labor utilization. The combination of these metrics suggests that the city is adding jobs, but the hours worked are slightly below the trend, which may indicate some level of labor market tightening. This signals a labor market with strong job growth but potential for inefficiencies.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Fresno is 7.70%, which is in the bottom tier, indicating a labor market with significant slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may find it easier to staff their operations due to the available workforce. However, the high unemployment rate also implies weaker local consumer demand, which could affect businesses reliant on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Fresno is 5.14%, which is above average, ranking in the 70th percentile. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also indicates good worker purchasing power. As wages grow faster than in many other cities, businesses may face increasing labor costs, but the local workforce will have more disposable income to spend.

Cost of Living

Fresno has a cost of living score that ranks in the 33rd percentile, with a price per square foot of \$263 and average hourly earnings of \$33.85, resulting in a ratio of 7.77. This indicates that the city is less affordable than many of its peers, which could make it harder to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The slight increase in PSF year-over-year further suggests that affordability is not improving.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Fresno is shrinking at a rate of -1.42% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor supply. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses looking to expand or establish operations in Fresno may face challenges in finding the necessary talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Fresno is -6.89%, which is near the median but still indicates a tightening in housing supply. This decrease in building permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Fresno is 57 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively slow pace indicates a buyer-friendly market, which could make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, the lack of change also suggests that the housing market is not becoming more competitive or dynamic.

Office Economy

Fresno's professional and office worker share ranks in the 36th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

In conclusion, Fresno offers a complex economic environment with strong labor demand but significant challenges, including a high unemployment rate and a shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for a business considering locating in Fresno is the potential difficulty in attracting and retaining talent due to the city's less affordable cost of living and tightening labor market.

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

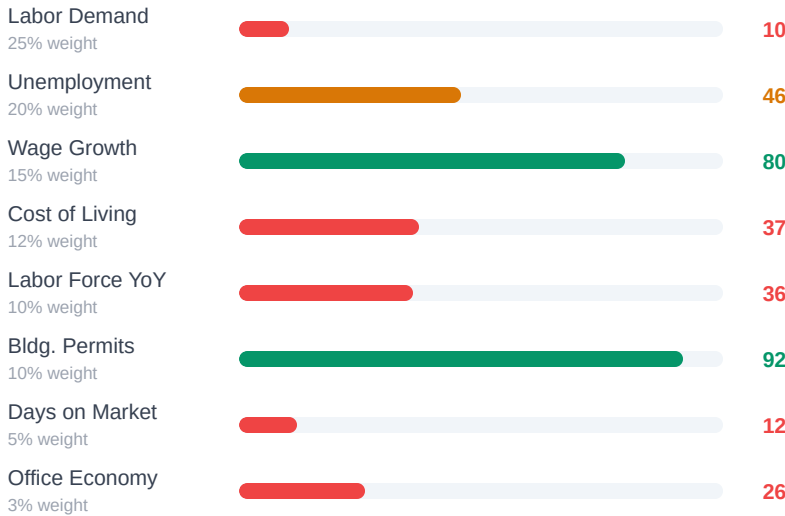
C+

POOR

42.3th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.9%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.5%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.7%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.9%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+77.2%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

40 days

median, -2.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it at the 42.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score of 3.27, and its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.54%. The combination of a -0.68% employment growth rate and a +0.075% weekly hours deviation signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is -0.68% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.075%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze, as hours are not significantly above trend during a period of job losses. The labor demand composite score of 3.27 ranks in the bottom tier, at the 10th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is 3.90%, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced labor market, neither extremely tight nor slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate suggests that finding talent may not be overly difficult, but it also may not be extremely easy, with some wage pressure possible.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is 5.54%, ranking in the top tier at the 80th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing worker purchasing power. Businesses operating in this city should be prepared for higher labor costs, but may also benefit from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk has a cost of living score ranking at the 37th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$224/sqft to \$35.13/hr, or 6.38. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, with a rising PSF trend of +3.2% year-over-year. The moderate affordability score suggests that attracting talent without wage premiums may be challenging, as the cost of living is above average compared to peer cities.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is contracting at a rate of -0.91% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This decline in labor force supply implies that hiring capacity may be constrained, making it more difficult for

businesses to find and attract talent in the area.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk has increased by 77.17% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This significant expansion in housing supply signals improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce, which could help attract and retain talent in the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is currently 40 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.4%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, ranking in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile, indicates a competitive market that may be challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk ranks below average at the 26th percentile, with a composite score of 1.82. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not as deep in specialized roles, making it less suited for tech, finance, or consulting businesses, but potentially more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and expanding housing supply, but also poses significant challenges due to its weak labor demand and constrained labor force growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited talent pool and competitive housing market, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain workers, ultimately affecting business operational costs and competitiveness.

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

C+

POOR

42.1th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		82
25% weight		
Unemployment		14
20% weight		
Wage Growth		34
15% weight		
Cost of Living		53
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		2
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		16
10% weight		
Days on Market		60
5% weight		
Office Economy		84
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 4.8%	WAGE GROWTH YOY +2.6% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.2% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -2.7% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -18.8% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 67 days median, -4.3% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 42.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with an 82nd percentile ranking, and its low unemployment rate, which is in the 14th percentile. The labor demand composite score of 6.34, driven by a +1.23% employment growth rate and +0.313% weekly hours deviation, signals genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +1.23% and weekly hours deviation of +0.313% indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.34 further reinforces this notion, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.80% is relatively low, ranking in the 14th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power, potentially driving up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +2.61% is below average, ranking in the 34th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate. However, workers may not see significant improvements in their purchasing power, which could impact consumer demand and the overall economy.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is near median, with a percentile rank of 53rd, and a PSF to earnings ratio of 7.03 (\$264/sqft vs \$37.56/hr). The fact that PSF is falling by -1.5% YoY is a positive sign for affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -2.70% year-over-year, ranking in the 2nd percentile. This decline in labor force supply suggests that the city may face structural headwinds in hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find and retain talent. The shrinking labor pool may also limit the city's ability to support long-term economic growth.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -18.76%, ranking in the 16th percentile, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that the city's housing market may become less affordable in the future, potentially making it more difficult for workers to relocate and for businesses to attract talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 67 days, with a year-over-year decline of -4.3%, ranking in the 60th percentile. This relatively fast pace of home sales suggests that the housing market is competitive, making it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing. However, the decline in days on market may indicate a normalization of the market, rather than a significant erosion of demand.

Office Economy

The city has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share of 3.52, ranking in the 84th percentile. This makes Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area offers a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, but its low unemployment rate and declining labor force supply pose significant challenges for businesses looking to hire and grow. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's shrinking labor pool, which may limit its ability to support long-term economic growth and make it challenging to attract and retain talent.

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

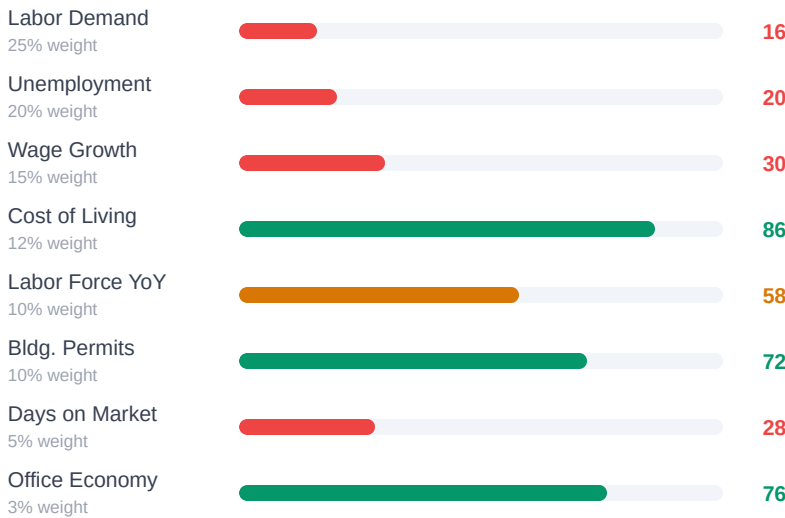
C+

POOR

39.5th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.7%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+2.2%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.8%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+0.1%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+19.2%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

68 days
median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked in the top tier at the 86th percentile. The labor demand is characterized by a low employment growth rate of 0.85% and a negative deviation in weekly hours of -1.731%.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 0.85%, which is relatively low, and the weekly hours deviation is -1.731%, indicating that hours are running below trend. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The low labor demand composite score of 3.99 further reinforces this assessment, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 4.70%, which is below average, ranking at the 20th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. The practical implication for a business trying to hire in this city is that it may face some competition for talent, but not to the extent that it would in a market with extremely low unemployment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 2.20%, which is below average, ranking at the 30th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not rapidly, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not strongly. The implication for employers is that they can expect some upward pressure on wages, but not to the extent that it would significantly impact their cost structure.

Cost of Living

San Antonio-New Braunfels has a highly affordable cost of living, with a percentile rank of 86, indicating that it is more affordable than most of its peer cities. The PSF to earnings ratio is \$170/sqft vs \$32.47/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.24, and the PSF is falling by 4.0% year-over-year. This affordability advantage means that businesses can attract talent without having to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Antonio-New Braunfels is growing at a rate of 0.10% year-over-year, which is near the median. This slow growth rate indicates that the labor force supply is expanding, but only slightly, which may pose a moderate challenge for businesses looking to hire in the city. The implication for hiring capacity is that businesses may need to be more competitive in their recruitment efforts to attract talent from a slowly growing labor pool.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Antonio-New Braunfels is increasing by 19.22% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking at the 72nd percentile. This rapid growth in building permits signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The implication for future affordability and workforce accommodation is positive, as the increased housing supply should help to keep costs in check.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 68 days, with a year-over-year change of 0.0%, ranking at the 28th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, where homes are selling quickly, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The implication for a worker relocating to this city is that they may need to act quickly to secure housing, as the market is competitive.

Office Economy

San Antonio-New Braunfels has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 76, indicating that it is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. The city's share of professional and office workers is 3.22, which is above average, further reinforcing its suitability for knowledge-economy businesses. However, it may be less suited for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area offers businesses a unique combination of affordability and access to a professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain types of businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the low labor demand, which may pose challenges for businesses looking to hire and expand in the city.

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

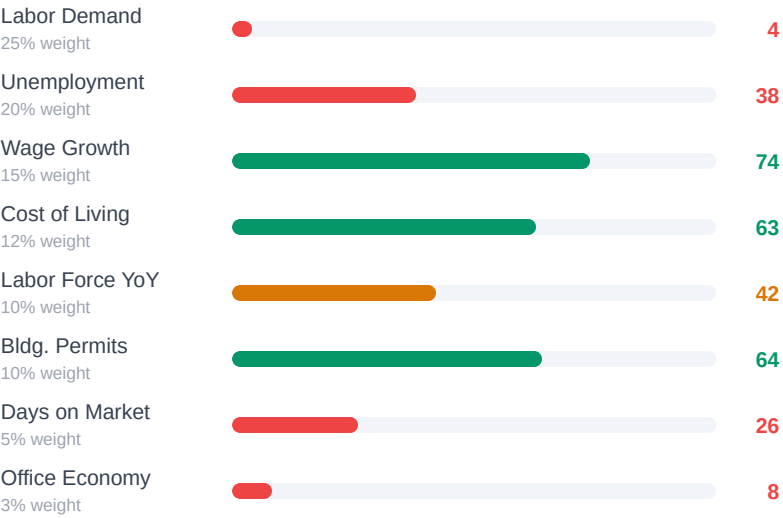
C+

POOR

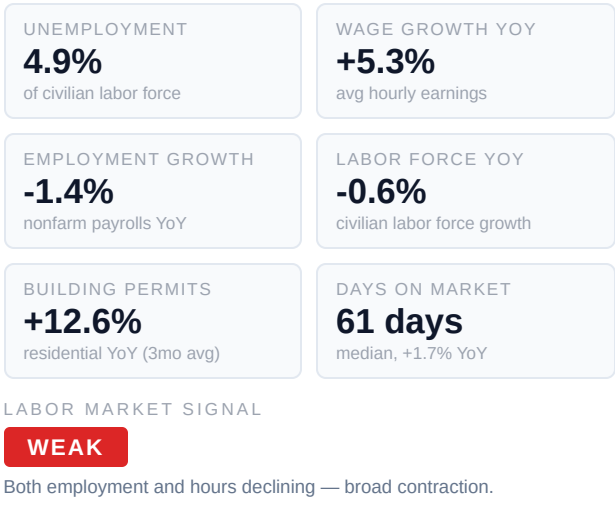
39.4th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score in the bottom tier at 4th percentile, and its above-average wage growth, at 74th percentile with a 5.27% year-over-year increase. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is -1.44% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.393% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. This scenario suggests that businesses may face a difficult time finding the talent they need to expand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 4.90%, ranking it below average at the 38th percentile. This indicates that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the relatively high unemployment rate also suggests weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses reliant on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 5.27%, placing it above average at the 74th percentile. This fast wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers but also indicates strong worker purchasing power. Businesses considering relocation should factor in the potential for higher labor costs due to the competitive wage environment.

Cost of Living

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a cost of living score ranking it 63rd percentile, with a PSF of \$304/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$42.18/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.21. The city's PSF is falling -2.2% year-over-year, contributing to its above-average affordability score. This makes the city more attractive for talent without requiring significant wage premiums, as the cost of living is relatively manageable compared to peer cities.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is growing at a rate of -0.58% year-over-year, ranking it near the median at the 42nd percentile. This indicates a slightly contracting labor pool, which could pose a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. Businesses should consider the potential challenges in finding and retaining talent in a shrinking labor market.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has increased by 12.62% year-over-year, ranking it above average at the 64th percentile. This rise in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce in the future. This trend is positive for businesses concerned about the ability of their employees to find affordable housing.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 61 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.7%, ranking it below average at the 26th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market that may be challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The rising days on market, although still relatively low, could signal a slight normalization of the housing market, but it remains competitive.

Office Economy

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a professional and office worker share ranking it in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, with a composite score of 0.68. This suggests a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors, making the city less suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations that require deep knowledge-economy talent. The city may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce requirements, such as industrial or logistics.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers businesses a unique combination of above-average wage growth and a relatively affordable cost of living, which could attract talent without significant wage premiums. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the weak labor demand and slightly contracting labor force, which could hinder business expansion and talent acquisition efforts.

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

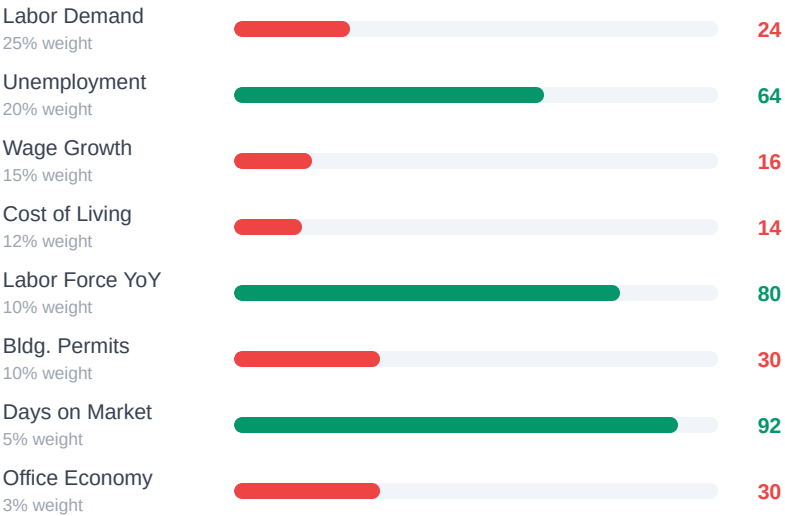
C+

POOR

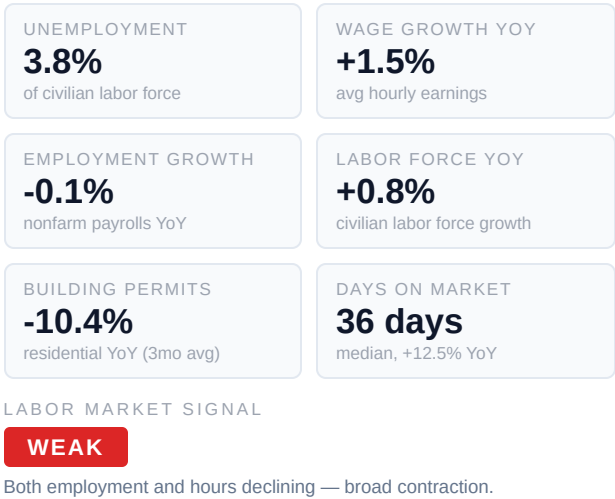
39.4th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 4.17 ranking it in the 24th percentile, and its slow wage growth, at +1.46% year-over-year, ranking it in the 16th percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is -0.09% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -1.171% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. Instead, it may be experiencing a period of job losses, which could lead to a survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 3.80%, ranking it in the 64th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that there is less slack in the market, making it harder for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face wage pressure and competition for talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Milwaukee-Waukesha is +1.46%, ranking it in the 16th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Milwaukee-Waukesha has a cost of living score ranking it in the 14th percentile, with a PSF of \$227/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.01/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.30. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is rising +2.2% year-over-year relative to wages further exacerbates the affordability issue, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Milwaukee-Waukesha is growing at a rate of +0.85% year-over-year, ranking it in the 80th percentile. This means that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. However, this growth may be offset by other challenges in the labor market.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Milwaukee-Waukesha is decreasing by -10.38% year-over-year, ranking it in the 30th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of +12.5%, ranking it in the 92nd percentile. This indicates a slower market, which could be beneficial for workers relocating to the city as it may give them more time to find a home. However, this could also signal a weakening demand for housing.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 1.94, ranking it in the 30th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors. As a result, this city may be better suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses rather than those requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area offers businesses a relatively tight labor market with slow wage growth, which could be beneficial for controlling labor costs. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively expensive cost of living and tightening housing supply, which could make it challenging to attract and accommodate talent without offering significant wage premiums.

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

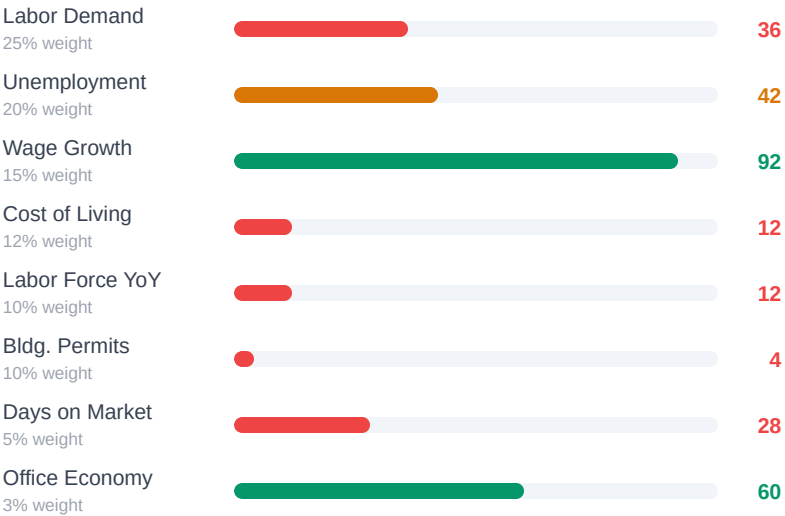
C

VERY POOR

37.5th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 37.5th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and office economy. The city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier wage growth of 6.72% year-over-year and its below-average labor demand composite score of 4.53. These metrics signal a complex labor market with both positive and negative trends.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 0.51% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.482% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a labor market with some job growth, but hours are not expanding as quickly as might be expected, indicating a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This suggests that while there is some demand for labor, it is not as strong as it could be.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 4.70%, which is near the median, ranking 42nd percentile. This indicates a labor market with some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to very tight markets. However, it also means that local consumer demand may not be as strong as in areas with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 6.72%, which is in the top tier, ranking 92nd percentile. This fast wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also means good news for worker purchasing power. Businesses considering locating in this area should be prepared for a competitive labor market where wages are increasing rapidly.

Cost of Living

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a cost of living that is relatively expensive, with a percentile rank of 12th, indicating that it is in the bottom tier for affordability. The city's PSF is \$594/sqft, which is decreasing by 2.8% year-over-year, but the ratio of PSF to hourly earnings of \$43.84/hr is still 13.55. This suggests that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is contracting at a rate of -1.75% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier, ranking 12th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, presenting a structural headwind for hiring and potentially limiting the city's ability to support business growth.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is decreasing by 37.09% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier, ranking 4th percentile. This sharp decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 45 days, with no year-over-year change. This indicates a relatively stable housing market that is neither extremely competitive nor very accessible for relocating workers. However, the lack of change in days on market, combined with the city's other labor market trends, suggests that the housing market may not be a major constraint for businesses locating in the area.

Office Economy

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has an above-average share of professional and office workers, ranking 60th percentile. This indicates a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, the city may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain types of companies. However, the city's high cost of living, shrinking labor force, and tightening housing supply present significant risks and constraints that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating this location for their business.

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

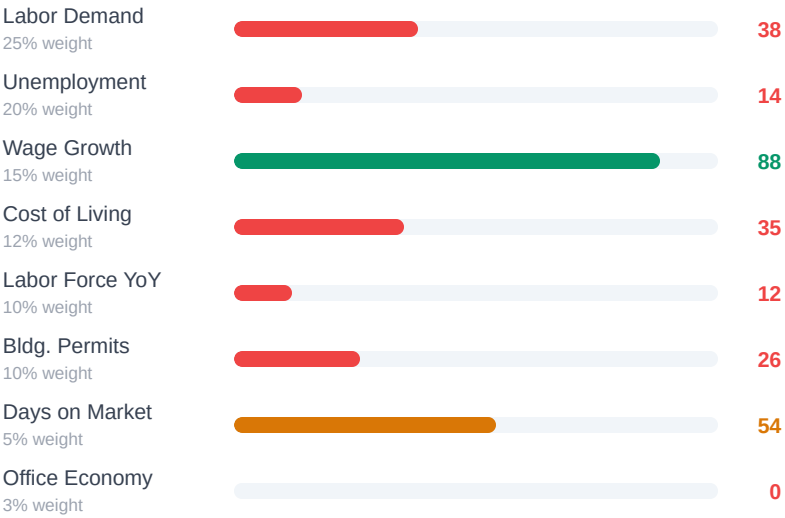
C

VERY POOR

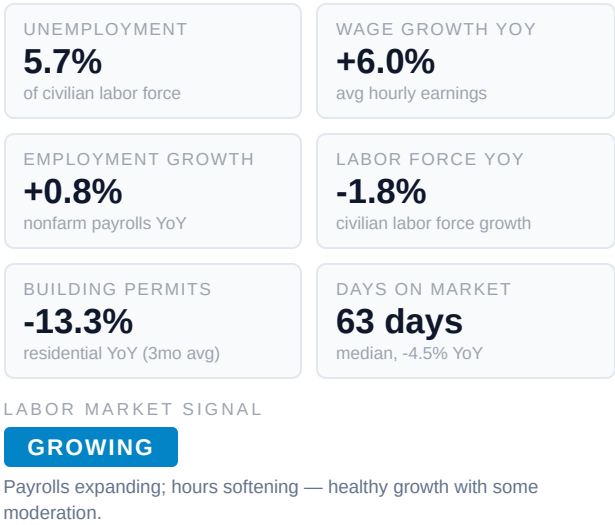
36.2th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low unemployment rate and high wage growth. The city's economic character is most defined by its 5.70% unemployment rate and 6.02% year-over-year wage growth, indicating a tight labor market with rising labor costs. These metrics suggest that the city's economy is experiencing a mix of positive and negative trends.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 0.79% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.845% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.56. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the modest job growth is accompanied by a decrease in hours worked. This suggests that the city's labor market is not experiencing genuine demand expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 5.70%, which is relatively high, indicating a labor market with some slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may have an easier time finding candidates, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The practical implication is that companies may need to consider the potential impact of a relatively high unemployment rate on their hiring and sales strategies.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 6.02%, which is relatively fast. This suggests that employer labor costs are rising, while worker purchasing power is increasing. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs when considering this location, while also benefiting from a workforce with increasing disposable income.

Cost of Living

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a cost of living score that ranks 35th percentile, with a PSF of \$332/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.60/hr, resulting in a ratio of 9.33. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, which may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling -1.2% year-over-year is a positive sign, but the overall affordability score remains below average.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is contracting at a rate of -1.75% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This implies that the city's hiring capacity may be constrained, making it more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need.

As a result, companies may need to consider alternative locations or strategies to attract workers.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is decreasing by -13.30% year-over-year, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. As a result, businesses may need to factor in the potential impact of a tightening housing market on their ability to attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 63 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -4.5%. This suggests that the housing market is relatively competitive, but still accessible for workers relocating to the city. The fact that days on market are decreasing indicates a relatively hot market, which may make it challenging for workers to find housing.

Office Economy

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a professional and office worker share that ranks 0th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies. On the other hand, the city may not be the best fit for tech, finance, or consulting firms that require a highly specialized workforce.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market with rising labor costs, and a relatively expensive cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's shrinking labor pool, which may limit the availability of talent and make it challenging for businesses to grow and expand. As a result, companies should carefully consider the potential implications of this trend when evaluating the city as a potential location.

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

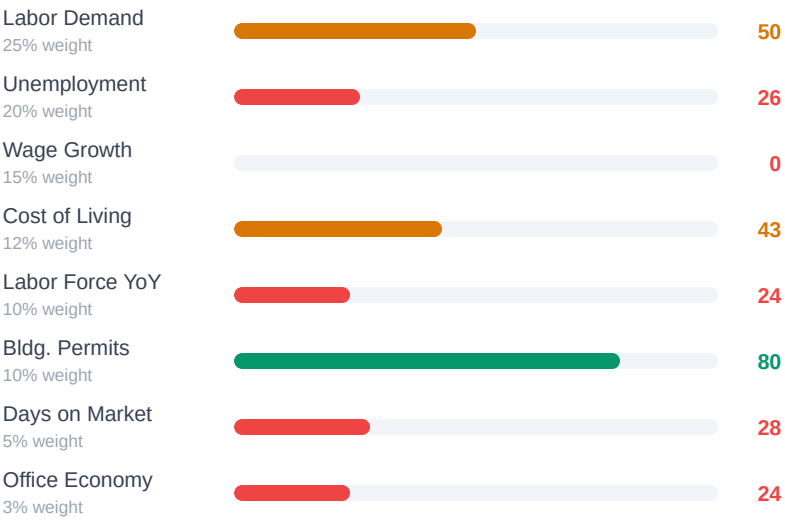
C

VERY POOR

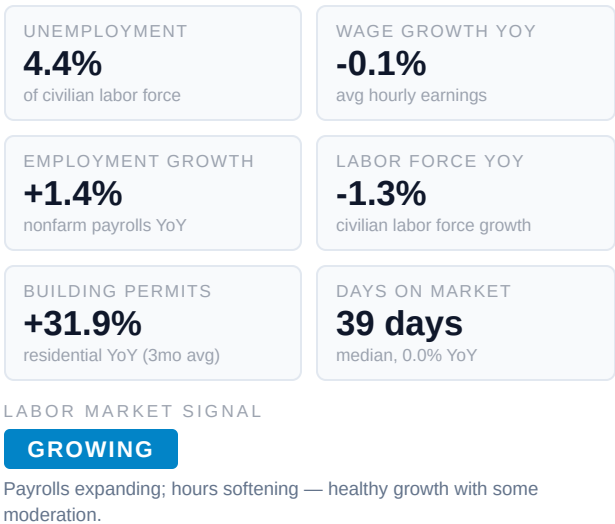
35.4th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 35.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score reflecting a mix of mediocre labor demand and cost of living metrics. The city's economic character is most defined by its stagnant wage growth, at -0.14% year-over-year, and its below-average labor force growth, at -1.32% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 1.36% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.894% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate expansion in job numbers, but with hours worked below trend, indicating some level of survivor squeeze where remaining workers may be absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 5.31 reflects this near-median performance.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 4.40%, ranking in the 26th percentile, indicating a below-average level of slack in the labor market. This suggests that the market is relatively tight, making it harder for businesses to hire, with potential upward pressure on wages. Companies looking to staff up may face challenges in finding available workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is -0.14%, ranking in the bottom tier, indicating stagnant wages. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. Businesses may benefit from a flat cost environment, but workers may not see significant increases in their earnings.

Cost of Living

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has a cost of living ratio of \$208/sqft to \$40.22/hr, with a percentile rank of 43, indicating a near-median level of affordability. The PSF is falling -1.9% year-over-year, which is a key driver of the city's affordability score. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage, as businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is contracting at a rate of -1.32% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction in labor supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face challenges in finding qualified

workers to fill open positions. The implications for hiring capacity are negative, with potential difficulties in staffing up.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is increasing by 31.92% year-over-year, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This rise in permits suggests that developer confidence is strong, and future housing supply is likely to increase, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. This is a positive signal for future affordability and workforce attraction.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 39 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking in the 28th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, which may be competitive for workers relocating to the city. However, the stable days on market suggests a balanced market, neither overly hot nor slow.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is below average, ranking in the 24th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and an expanding housing supply, which could accommodate a growing workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the stagnant wage growth and contracting labor force, which may limit the availability of qualified workers and create challenges for talent attraction and retention.

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

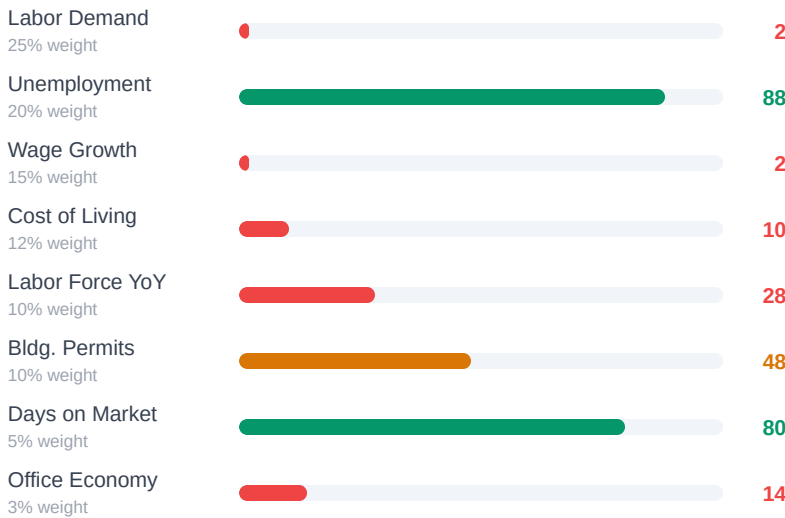
C-

CRITICAL

31.6th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.4%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.1%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-1.2%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.0%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-3.1%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

51 days
median, +8.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 31.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a labor demand composite score in the bottom tier at 2.22, and its tight unemployment market, with an unemployment rate of 3.40% ranking in the top tier at 88th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is -1.17% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.446%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. The positive deviation in weekly hours may suggest a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 3.40%, ranking in the top tier at 88th percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent in this competitive market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is +0.09%, ranking in the bottom tier. This stagnant wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and limited growth in worker purchasing power. This may impact the overall attractiveness of the city to businesses and workers alike.

Cost of Living

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has a cost of living score in the bottom tier at 10th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$165/sqft to \$33.45/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.93. The city's PSF is rising by 4.4% year-over-year, indicating increasing costs. This makes the city relatively expensive compared to its peers, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is contracting at a rate of -0.99% year-over-year, ranking below average at 28th percentile. This decline in labor force supply may create a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find the talent they need to expand or maintain operations.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is declining by -3.15% year-over-year, ranking near the median at 48th percentile. This suggests that the housing supply is not expanding rapidly, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 8.5%, ranking in the top tier at 80th percentile. This indicates a slower market, which may be more accessible for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find a home.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is relatively low, ranking in the bottom tier at 14th percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not as deep in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for businesses in tech, finance, or consulting, but potentially more suitable for industries with different skill requirements.

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area offers businesses a tight labor market with low unemployment, but this also comes with challenges in hiring and potentially rising wage pressures. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand and declining labor force growth, which may limit the availability of talent and create challenges for businesses looking to expand or maintain operations in the area.

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

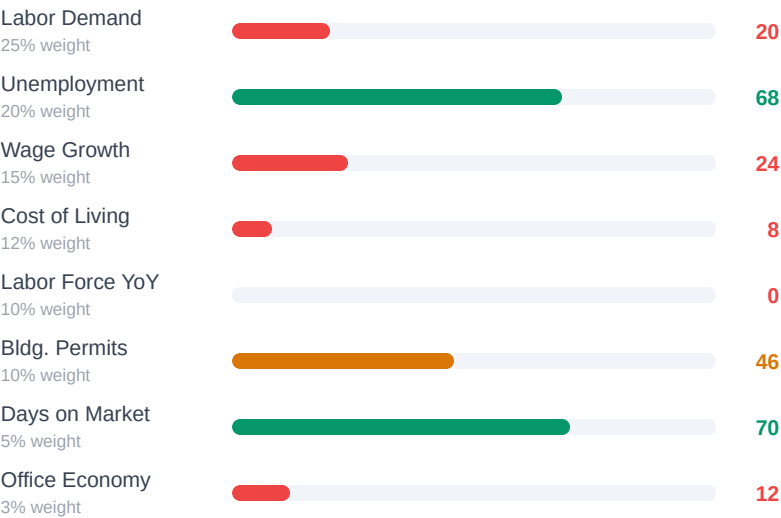
C-

CRITICAL

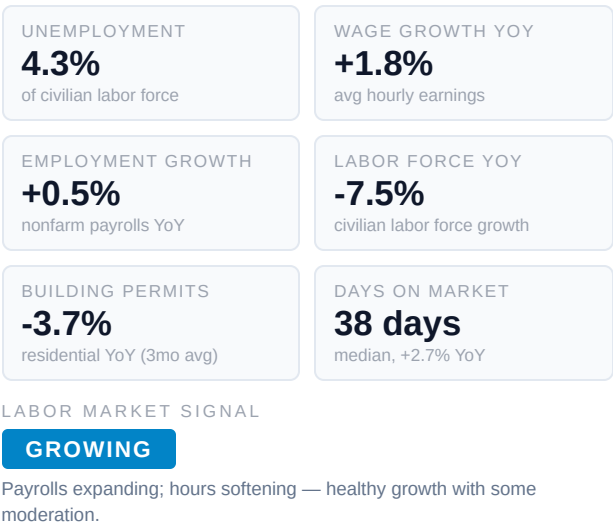
31.6th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 31.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand composite score of 4.11, ranking in the 20th percentile, and its high cost of living ratio of 6.66, which places it in the 8th percentile for affordability. These metrics suggest a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is +0.47% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.851% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The low labor demand composite score of 4.11 further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 4.30%, which ranks in the 68th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The tight market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is +1.83%, which is below average and ranks in the 24th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in other cities. Workers in the area may see some increase in purchasing power, but it may not be as significant as in other locations.

Cost of Living

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has a cost of living ratio of 6.66, with a PSF of \$217/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$32.56/hr. The city's cost of living percentile rank is 8th, indicating that it is relatively expensive compared to its peers. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the high cost of living may be a deterrent for workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is contracting at a rate of -7.49% year-over-year, ranking in the 0th percentile. This significant decline in labor force supply suggests that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is decreasing at a rate of -3.73% year-over-year, ranking near the median at 46th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply may be tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 38 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.7%. This ranks in the 70th percentile, indicating a relatively slow market. For workers relocating to the city, this may be a competitive advantage, as they may have more time to find a home and negotiate a better price.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is relatively low, ranking in the 12th percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not as deep in knowledge-economy sectors, making it less suited for tech, finance, or consulting businesses. However, the city may be more attractive to industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area offers businesses a relatively tight labor market with moderate wage growth, but its high cost of living and declining labor force supply pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor force growth, which may hinder hiring capacity and business expansion plans.

Richmond

Richmond

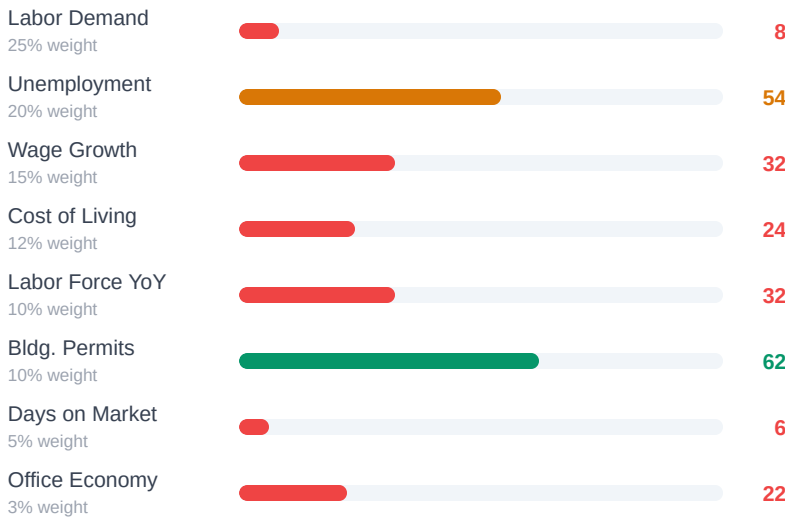
C-

CRITICAL

30.9th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.8%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+2.5%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.8%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.9%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+10.3%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

44 days

median, -4.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand composite score of 3.24, which ranks in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, and its unemployment rate of 3.80%, which is near the median at the 54th percentile. These metrics suggest a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Richmond is -0.76% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.415% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job growth and hours worked. This suggests a lack of genuine demand expansion, which could be a concern for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.80%, which is near the median at the 54th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, but not excessively so. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate means that there may be a sufficient pool of candidates, but wage pressure may not be as intense as in tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Richmond is +2.49%, which ranks below average at the 32nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. However, worker purchasing power may not be increasing as quickly as in other cities with faster wage growth.

Cost of Living

Richmond has a cost of living score that ranks below average at the 24th percentile, with a PSF of \$228/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.92/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.35. This suggests that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is increasing by 1.8% year-over-year further exacerbates the affordability concern. This may make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Richmond is contracting at a rate of -0.94% year-over-year, which ranks below average at the 32nd percentile. This decline in labor force supply suggests that the city may face structural headwinds in hiring and expanding its workforce. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract talent from other areas or invest in workforce development programs.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Richmond is increasing by 10.33% year-over-year, which ranks above average at the 62nd percentile. This expansion in housing supply suggests that the city may be becoming more affordable and accommodating for its workforce. However, the current pace of growth may not be sufficient to meet demand, and businesses should monitor this metric closely.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Richmond is 44 days, with a year-over-year decline of -4.3%. This suggests that the housing market is relatively competitive, and homes are selling quickly. For a worker relocating to this city, this may mean that they need to act fast to secure housing, which could be a challenge.

Office Economy

Richmond's office economy is below average, with a percentile rank of 22. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors. The city may be better suited for businesses that are not heavily reliant on specialized office talent, such as industrial or logistics companies. However, businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors may find it challenging to attract the necessary talent.

The Richmond metro area offers a mixed bag for businesses, with some challenges in labor demand, cost of living, and labor force growth. However, the city's expanding housing supply and moderate unemployment rate may provide some opportunities for businesses looking to relocate or expand. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively expensive cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract talent.

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

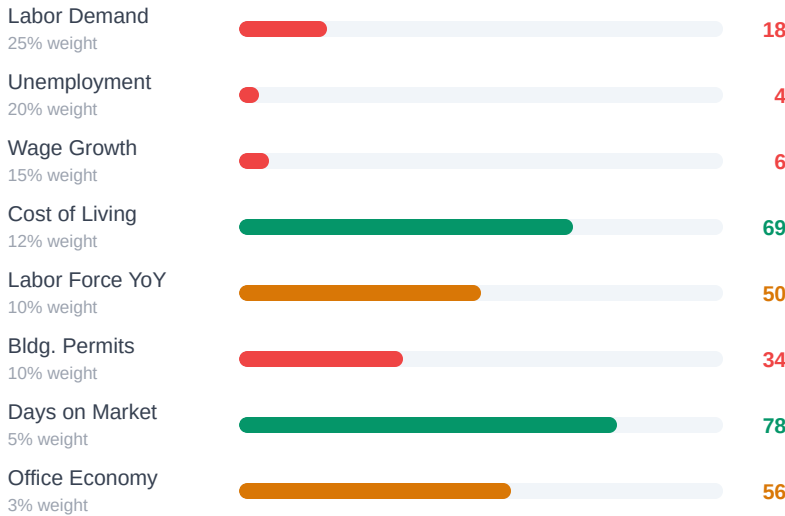
C-

CRITICAL

28.5th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.9%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.4%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.4%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.3%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-10.3%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

65 days
median, -12.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Jacksonville has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 28.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 4.01 ranking in the bottom tier at 18th percentile, and its high unemployment rate of 4.90%, which ranks in the bottom tier at 4th percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

Jacksonville's employment growth rate is +0.36% year-over-year, but weekly hours are deviating -0.794% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are not increasing despite modest job growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.01 reinforces this assessment, ranking in the bottom tier at 18th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Jacksonville is 4.90%, ranking in the bottom tier at 4th percentile, which means the market has significant slack. This implies that businesses trying to hire in Jacksonville may find it easier to staff, but may also face weaker local consumer demand due to the higher unemployment rate. The low unemployment percentile rank suggests that the city's labor market is not tight, giving employers more flexibility in hiring.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Jacksonville is +0.39% year-over-year, which is a stagnant rate ranking in the bottom tier at 6th percentile. This slow wage growth implies a flat cost environment for employers, but weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost pressures, but workers may not have strong purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Jacksonville has a cost of living score ranking in the 69th percentile, with a PSF of \$214/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.85/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.81. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage without requiring wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling -2.3% year-over-year further supports the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Jacksonville is growing at a rate of -0.29% year-over-year, ranking near the median at 50th percentile. This means that the labor force supply is contracting, which could pose a structural headwind for hiring in the city. Businesses may need to consider this constraint when planning their workforce expansion.

Building Permits

Building permits in Jacksonville are decreasing at a rate of -10.28% year-over-year, ranking below average at 34th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This trend may signal a potential risk for businesses relying on a mobile workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Jacksonville is 65 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -12.2%, ranking above average at 78th percentile. This means that homes are sitting on the market for a relatively long time, making it a more accessible market for workers relocating to the city. However, this trend may also indicate a slower market, which could have implications for the local real estate industry.

Office Economy

Jacksonville's professional and office worker share ranks near the median at 56th percentile, with a composite score of 2.74. This suggests that the city has a moderately deep talent pool, making it suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and non-professional roles. However, it may not be the best fit for businesses that require a highly specialized or knowledge-intensive workforce.

In conclusion, Jacksonville offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a slack labor market, which could be advantageous for hiring and expansion. However, the city's low labor demand, stagnant wage growth, and tightening housing supply pose significant risks and constraints that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating Jacksonville as a potential business location. The single biggest risk is the potential for future affordability issues and workforce accommodation challenges, which could impact businesses relying on a mobile workforce.

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

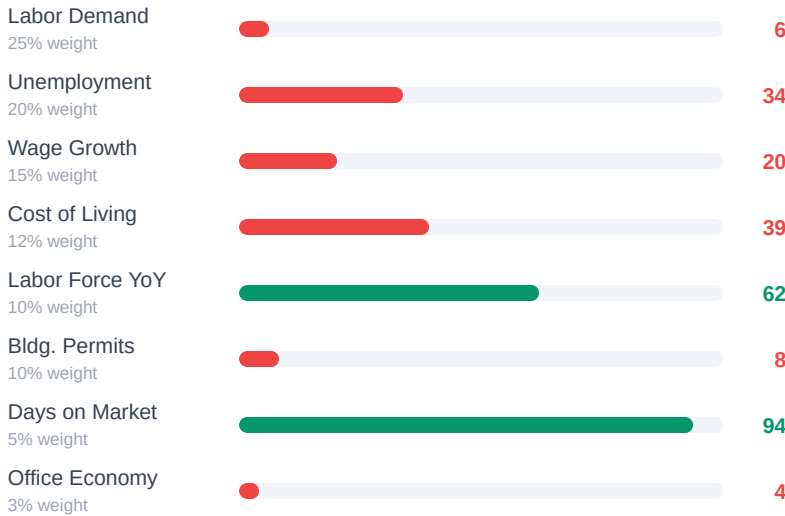
C-

CRITICAL

27.8th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.8%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.6%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+0.2%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-31.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

44 days

median, +12.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

4 Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 27.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a labor demand composite score of 2.99, and its slow wage growth, at +1.61% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is -0.07% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +1.215%. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. This is a concern for businesses looking to hire, as it may indicate a lack of job creation and a tight labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is 4.80%, ranking it in the 34th percentile. This indicates a market with some slack, but not excessively so. For a business trying to hire, this means that while it may not be extremely difficult to find workers, there is still some competition for talent, and wages may be subject to upward pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Louisville-Jefferson County is +1.61%, which is below average. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. This could impact the local consumer demand and the overall economic vitality of the area.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$178/sqft to \$31.29/hr, Louisville-Jefferson County ranks in the 39th percentile for affordability. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising by +0.6% year-over-year relative to wages further exacerbates this issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Louisville-Jefferson County is growing at a rate of +0.25% year-over-year, which is above average. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. However, the slow labor force growth rate may not be enough to keep up with demand, potentially leading to some labor market tightness.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Louisville-Jefferson County has decreased by -31.66% year-over-year. This sharp decline signals that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This is a concern for businesses that may need to attract workers from other areas.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Louisville-Jefferson County is 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of +12.8%. This ranks in the top tier, indicating a slower market. For a worker relocating to this city, this means that they may have more time to find a home and negotiate a better price, making the city more accessible to newcomers.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Louisville-Jefferson County is 0.38, ranking it in the 4th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, the city may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area offers a relatively slow-growing economy with some challenges in labor demand and affordability. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the tight labor market and the potential for future affordability issues, which could impact the ability to attract and retain talent. Despite these challenges, the city's expanding labor force and slower housing market may provide some opportunities for businesses that can navigate these complexities.

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

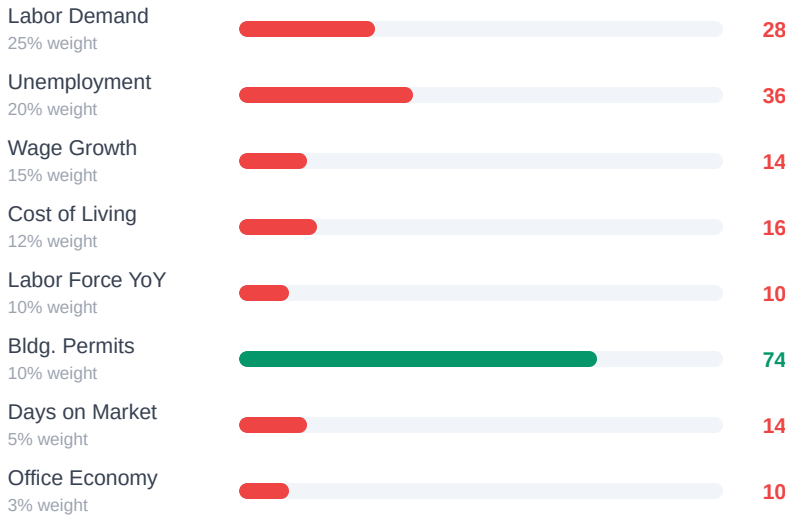
C-

CRITICAL

27.7th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

5.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.3%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.9%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+21.9%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

50 days

median, -2.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 27.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand composite score of 4.32, ranking it at the 28th percentile, and its stagnant wage growth of +1.05% year-over-year, ranking it at the 14th percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +0.34% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.457% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the small increase in employment is accompanied by a decrease in hours worked. This suggests that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 5.00%, ranking it at the 36th percentile. This indicates that the market has some slack, but it is not extremely loose. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate means that there may be a pool of available workers, but it may not be as large as in cities with higher unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +1.05%, ranking it at the 14th percentile. This stagnant wage growth signals that labor costs for employers are not rising quickly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing rapidly. This may make it harder for businesses to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has a cost of living score ranking it at the 16th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$339/sqft to \$38.15/hr, or 8.89. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that the PSF is falling -0.9% year-over-year is a positive sign, but overall, the city's high cost of living may make it harder to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is contracting at a rate of -1.92% year-over-year, ranking it at the 10th percentile. This means that the supply of workers is shrinking, which may create a structural headwind for hiring in the city. Businesses looking to expand or relocate may face challenges in finding the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is increasing by +21.94% year-over-year, ranking it at the 74th percentile. This signals that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and make it easier for workers to relocate to the city. However, the current pace of growth may not be enough to fully address the city's affordability challenges.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 50 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.0%. This relatively fast pace of home sales may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing, as the market is still relatively competitive.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 0.72, ranking it at the 10th percentile. This indicates that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making it less suited for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting industries. However, the city may be more attractive to businesses in industries that are less dependent on specialized office talent.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area offers businesses a relatively low-cost labor environment, but it also presents significant challenges in terms of labor demand, wage growth, and cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's shrinking labor force, which may limit the availability of talent and create hiring challenges for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

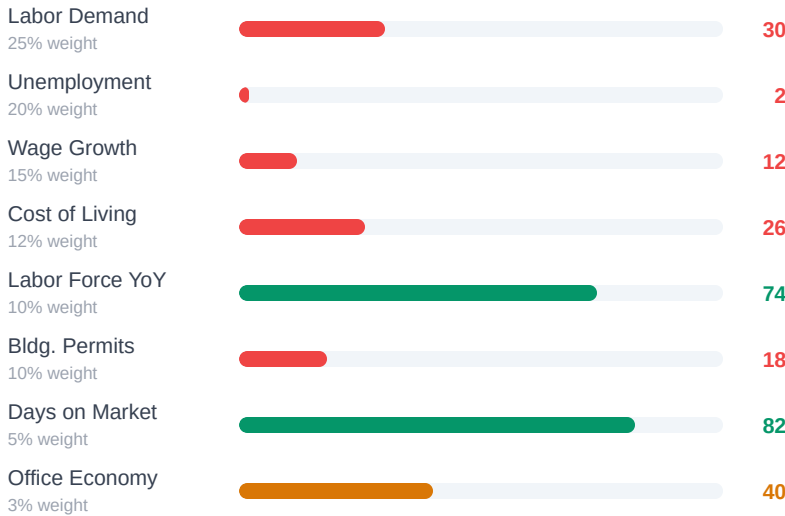
C-

CRITICAL

27.4th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

6.0%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.6%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.2%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+0.7%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-18.7%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

40 days
median, +5.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 27.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 6.00% and its below-average labor demand composite score of 4.43, which signals a mix of slow employment growth and decreased weekly hours. These metrics, particularly the unemployment rate and labor demand, set the tone for the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is +0.16% year-over-year, combined with a -0.098% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicating a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that while there is some job growth, the decrease in hours worked per week may indicate a degree of survivor squeeze, where remaining workers absorb the workload of eliminated roles. This scenario does not strongly support rapid business expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn stands at 6.00%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile, which signifies a tight labor market with considerable slack. For a business trying to hire in this market, the low unemployment rate implies that it may be challenging to find suitable candidates, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is +0.60%, placing it in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth environment suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly, which could impact local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has a cost of living score that ranks it in the 26th percentile, with a PSF of \$186/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.68, resulting in a ratio of 5.07. This indicates that the city is less affordable than many of its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is increasing by 1.6% year-over-year further reduces the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is growing at a rate of +0.69% year-over-year, ranking it above average at the 74th percentile. This expansion in the labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers.

Building Permits

The city experienced a -18.71% year-over-year change in residential building permits, placing it in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This significant decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn are currently sitting on the market for a median of 40 days, with a year-over-year increase of 5.3%, ranking it in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This slower market means that workers relocating to the city may find it easier to find and purchase a home, as the market is less competitive.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn ranks near the median at the 40th percentile, indicating a moderate depth of professional talent. This makes the city more suited for businesses that do not require a deeply specialized knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics operations, rather than tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area offers a mix of challenges and opportunities for businesses, with its tight labor market and slow wage growth being significant factors. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to consider is the city's tightening housing supply, signaled by the sharp decline in building permits, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in attracting and retaining talent.

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

C-

CRITICAL

27.2th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		46
25% weight		
Unemployment		22
20% weight		
Wage Growth		44
15% weight		
Cost of Living		22
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		4
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		0
10% weight		
Days on Market		10
5% weight		
Office Economy		38
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.9% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.1% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.2% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -2.5% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -42.4% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 36 days median, -2.7% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 27.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor force growth rate of -2.46% YoY and a significant decline in building permits of -42.35% YoY, indicating structural challenges in expanding its workforce and housing supply. The labor demand composite score of 5.21, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile, suggests a relatively stable but unremarkable job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +0.17% YoY, combined with a +0.674% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, signaling a genuine but modest demand expansion. This combination indicates that while jobs are being added, the increase in hours worked suggests that the existing workforce is being utilized more intensely, which could be a sign of a tightening labor market. However, the near-median percentile rank of 46th suggests that this demand is not exceptionally strong compared to other metros.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin stands at 4.90%, ranking below average at the 22nd percentile, which indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack. For a business trying to hire in this market, the implication is that while it may be somewhat challenging to find talent, it is not as competitive as in markets with even lower unemployment rates. This could mean slightly higher wage pressure to attract and retain employees.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +3.11%, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile, indicating a moderate pace of wage increases. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising but not at an alarming rate, and worker purchasing power is increasing, which can support local consumer demand. However, for businesses, this means anticipating and planning for gradual increases in labor costs.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$221/sqft to \$37.34/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.92, and a percentile rank of 22nd, Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is considered below average in terms of affordability. This means the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the higher cost of living. The 3.8% YoY increase in PSF further exacerbates this issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is contracting at a rate of -2.46% YoY, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing, which could exacerbate talent acquisition challenges for businesses locating or expanding in the area.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -42.35%, signaling a sharp decline in housing supply expansion. This significant decrease suggests that the future affordability of housing and the ability to accommodate a growing workforce are at risk, potentially leading to increased costs for both workers and employers and making the area less attractive for relocation.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 36 days, with a -2.7% YoY change, indicating a relatively fast-paced market that is slightly slowing down. For a worker relocating to this city, the market is still competitive, meaning homes are selling relatively quickly, which could make finding suitable housing challenging and may require acting rapidly when a suitable property is found.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share composite score ranking below average at the 38th percentile, Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a moderately deep talent pool suited for professional and office sectors. This city is more suited for businesses that can leverage a diverse economy with a notable presence of professional roles, though it may not be as ideal for those requiring a highly specialized tech or finance talent pool.

In conclusion, Chicago-Naperville-Elgin offers a business a relatively stable job market and moderate wage growth, but it comes with significant challenges in labor force expansion and housing supply, which are critical for long-term growth and talent attraction. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the shrinking labor pool and tightening housing market, which could lead to increased labor and housing costs, making it essential to carefully weigh these factors in any location decision.